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Left Turn

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An exchange about a Green New Deal

Robert Pollin and Don Fitz

Decolonizing Minds, Including My Own

Gary Olson

**Double Deformation:
Capital v. Nature & Humanity**

Michael A. Lebowitz

Guantanamo Past the Point of All Shame

David Swanson

**Interstellar slavery:
coming to a planet near you?**

A poem by Raymond Nat Turner

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Notes from the Editor

Global capitalism's race to the bottom (and for the bottom line) is not only generating runaway economic inequalities, social unrest, and political dysfunctionality, but also a race off the ecological cliff in the near future.

A study that looked at average temperature and precipitation changes only, excluding the most extreme impacts, found that at least 85% of the world's population has experienced climate change-induced weather events and that 80% of the world's land area has been affected as well. One must live a life of complete isolation and ignorance not to have seen terrifying images of wildfires in California, record-breaking heatwaves in Canada and Italy, deadly floods in Germany, China, South Sudan, of New Yorkers drowning in their own homes, and so on. Heatwaves have killed hundreds of people this summer in usually temperate regions of the world, such as the Pacific Northwest. More than a million people in Madagascar, the same study reports, are facing starvation "as a historic drought morphs into a climate-induced famine."

"The climate crisis is the single biggest health threat facing humanity" states an open letter to world leaders by over 3,400 individuals from 102 countries from over 450 organizations representing 45 million health-care workers. Global warming "could be far more catastrophic and enduring than the COVID-19 pandemic" as it increases the risk of many health issues, including breathing problems, mental illness, insect-borne diseases, deaths from heart disease, etc.

The short-term central task of any movement for the future is to figure out how to compel the recalcitrant political and economic forces that dominate the state and society today to act decisively to reverse the accelerating trends towards ecological catastrophe. The crucial long-term task is to altogether dismantle the institutional structure of global capitalism, a system most directly responsible for the present global ecological emergency, and replace it with a radically different socioeconomic order. Naming the system and identifying the capitalist logic that governs it is absolutely necessary for the liberatory project, the movement for going beyond it in the long-term and constraining it in the near-term.

We cannot expect anything beyond fragmentary and inadequate measures to combat climate crisis from the political system as it is presently constituted. At best it may combat some of the symptoms of the ecological crisis but not the root causes and thereby it will be complicit in the ecological disasters that have already begun to affect all life on this planet. This fact alone

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Discussion of a specific Green New Deal program for California.

Interviews conducted by C.J. Polychroniou

Interviews originally appeared in Truthout

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Robert Pollin is Distinguished University Professor of Economics and Co-Director of the Political Economy Research Institute (PERI) at the University of Massachusetts Amherst. His recent work on this issue includes the books *Greening the Global Economy and Climate Crisis* and the *Global Green New Deal* (co-authored with Noam Chomsky), as well as green transformation programs for 9 U.S. states—New York, Washington, Colorado, Maine, Ohio, Pennsylvania, West Virginia, and California.¹ He is currently also working with the national Green New Deal Network (<https://www.greennewdealnetwork.org/>) to develop and advance the national THRIVE Agenda—a program to “Transform, Heal, and Renew by Investing in a Vibrant Economy.”²

Don Fitz (fitzdon@aol.com) has taught Environmental Psychology at Washington University and Fontbonne University in St. Louis and is on the Editorial Board of *Green Social Thought* where a version of this article was first published. He was the 2016 candidate of the Missouri Green Party for Governor. His book on *Cuban Health Care: The Ongoing Revolution* has been available since June 2020.

1 <https://peri.umass.edu/publication/item/1032-green-new-deal-for-u-s-states>

2 <https://peri.umass.edu/publication/item/1397-employment-impacts-of-proposed-u-s-economic-stimulus-programs>

ROBERT POLLIN'S 1ST ARTICLE

Labor Unions Rally Behind California's Zero-Emissions Climate Plan

C.J. Polychroniou: *Since the idea of a Green New Deal entered into public consciousness, the debate about climate emergency is becoming increasingly polarized between those advocating “green growth” and those arguing in support of “degrowth.” What exactly does “degrowth” mean, and is this at the end of the day an economic or an ideological debate?*

Robert Pollin: Let me first say that I don't think that the debate on the climate emergency between advocates of degrowth versus the Green New Deal is becoming increasingly polarized, certainly not as a broad generalization. Rather, as an advocate of the Green New Deal and critic of degrowth, I would still say that there are large areas of agreement along with some significant differences. For example, I agree that uncontrolled economic growth produces serious environmental damage along with increases in the supply of goods and services that households, businesses, and governments consume. I also agree that a significant share of what is produced and consumed in the current global capitalist economy is wasteful, especially much, if not most, of what high-income people throughout the world consume. It is also obvious that growth per se as an economic category makes no reference to the distribution of the costs and benefits of an expanding economy. I think it is good to keep in mind both the areas of agreement as well as the differences.

But what about definitions: what do we actually mean by the Green New Deal and degrowth?

Starting with the Green New Deal: the Intergovernmental Panel on Climate Change (IPCC) estimates that for the global economy to move onto a viable climate stabilization path, global emissions of carbon dioxide (CO₂) will have to fall by about 45 percent as of 2030 and reach net zero emissions by 2050. As such, by my definition, the core of the global Green New Deal is to advance a global project to hit these IPCC targets, and to accomplish this in a way that also expands decent job opportunities and raises mass living standards for working people and the poor throughout the world. The single most important project within the Green New Deal entails phasing out the consumption of oil, coal, and natural gas to produce energy, since burning fossil fuels is responsible for about 70–75 percent of all global CO₂ emissions. We then have to build an entirely new global energy infrastructure, whose centerpieces are high efficiency and clean renewable energy sources—primarily solar and wind power. The investments required to dramatically increase energy efficiency standards and to equally dramatically expand the global supply of clean energy sources will also be a huge source of new job creation, in all regions of the world. These are the basics of the Green New Deal as I see it. It is that simple in concept, while also providing specific pathways for achieving its overarching goals.

Now on degrowth: since I am not a supporter, it would be unfair for me to be the one explaining what it means. So here is how some of the leading degrowth

proponents themselves describe the concept and movement. For example, in a 2015 edited volume titled *Degrowth: A Vocabulary for a New Era*¹, the volume's editors Giacomo D'Alisa, Frederico Demaria and Giorgos Kallis, write that "The foundational theses of degrowth are that growth is uneconomic and unjust, that it is ecologically unsustainable and that it will never be enough (2015, p. 6)." More recently, a 2021 paper by Riccardo Mastini, Giorgos Kallis and Jason Hickel titled "A Green New Deal without Growth?" write that "ecological economists have defined degrowth as an equitable downscaling of throughput, with a concomitant securing of wellbeing."²

It is instructive here that, in this 2021 paper, Mastini, Kallis and Hickel do also acknowledge that degrowth has not advanced into developing a specific set of economic programs, writing that "degrowth is not a political platform, but rather an 'umbrella concept' that brings together a wide variety of ideas and social struggles." This acknowledgement reflects, in my view, a major ongoing weakness with the degrowth literature, which is that, in concerning itself primarily with very broad themes, it actually gives almost no detailed attention to developing an effective climate stabilization project, or any other specific ecological project. Indeed, this deficiency was reflected in a 2017 interview with the leading ecological economist Herman Daly himself, without question a major intellectual progenitor of the degrowth movement. Daly says in the interview that he is "favorably inclined" toward degrowth, but nevertheless demurs that he is "still waiting for them to get beyond the slogan and develop something a little more concrete," (p. 102).³

This lack of specificity among degrowth proponents leads to further problems. For example, degrowth supporters, such as Mastini et al. in their 2021 paper, are clear that they support the transformation of the global energy system along the lines that I have described above, from our current fossil fuel-dominant system to one whose core features are high efficiency and clean renewable energy sources. Yet in fact, building out this new energy system will obviously entail massive growth of the global clean energy system, just as it will equally entail the phasing out—or degrowth, if you prefer—of the global fossil fuel energy system. In my view, it is more useful to be specific about which sectors of the global economy will certainly need to grow—e.g. the clean energy system—while others, like fossil fuels, contract, as opposed to invoking sweeping generalities about degrowth. We can extend this point. For example, I am sure degrowth proponents would favor major expansions in access to public education, universal health care, high-quality affordable housing, regenerative agriculture, and the share of the earth's surface covered by forests.

In focusing on some critical specifics, I would also add that there is no way that a general project of degrowth can put the global economy onto a viable climate stabilization path. With the COVID-19 recession, the global economy just went through a powerful natural experiment to demonstrate this point. That is, during the pandemic in 2020, the global economy contracted by 3.5 percent, which the International Monetary Fund described as a "severe collapse . . . that has had acute adverse impacts on women, youth, the poor, the informally employed and those who work in contact-intensive sectors."⁴ In other words, the pandemic produced an intense period of global 'degrowth.' This recession did also produce a decline in emissions, as entire sections of the global economy were forced into lockdown mode. But the emissions decline

amounted to only 6.4 percent over 2020.⁵ Remember, the IPCC tells us that we need to cut emissions by 45 percent as of 2030 and be at zero emissions by 2050. If the COVID recession only yields a 6.4 percent emissions reduction despite the enormous levels of economic pain inflicted, clearly 'degrowth' cannot come close, on its own, to delivering a 45 percent emissions cut by 2030, much less a zero emissions global economy by 2050.

CJP: *Those who see the Green New Deal not only as the most effective strategy to tackle global warming but also as an engine of growth, such as yourself, rely on the concept of "decoupling." However, "degrowth" advocates seem to be arguing that there is no empirical evidence for absolute "decoupling," and that it's highly unlikely that it will ever happen. How do you respond to such claims?*

RP: Let's recognize, to begin with, that people are still going to need to consume energy to light, heat, and cool buildings, to power cars, buses, trains, and airplanes, and to operate computers and industrial machinery, among other uses. As one critical example here, in low-income economies, delivering adequate supplies of affordable electricity becomes transformative for people's lives, enabling them, for example, to adequately light their homes at night rather than relying on kerosene lanterns. As such, it should be our goal to greatly expand access to electricity to low-income communities throughout the world, while we are also driving down CO₂ emissions to zero. The solution is for energy consumption and economic activity more generally to be absolutely decoupled from the generation of CO₂ emissions. That is, the consumption of fossil fuel energy will need to fall steadily and dramatically in absolute terms, even while people will still be able to consume energy resources to meet their various demands. The more modest goal of relative decoupling—through which fossil fuel energy consumption and CO₂ emissions continue to increase, but at a slower rate than overall economic activity—is therefore not a solution. Economies can still continue to grow while still advancing a viable climate stabilization project as long as the growth process is absolutely decoupled from fossil fuel consumption.

Is absolute decoupling impossible to accomplish within the context of economic growth? To date, we have seen some modest evidence—and I do stress the evidence is modest—of absolute decoupling taking place. For example, between 2000 and 2014, 21 countries, including the U.S., Germany, the U.K., Spain and Sweden, all managed to absolutely decouple GDP growth from CO₂ emissions—i.e. GDP in these countries expanded over this 14-year period while CO₂ emissions fell.⁶ This is a positive development, but only a small step in the right direction.

The way to deliver a much more rapid pattern of absolute decoupling is, of course, to build out the global clean energy economy, and to do so quickly. This is a feasible project. By my own estimates, it requires that the global economy spend approximately 2.5 percent of global GDP per year on investments in energy efficiency and clean renewable energy supplies, while the global economy grows at an average rate of about 3 percent per year between now and 2050.⁷ The International Renewable Energy Agency⁸ and International Energy Agency⁹ recently published studies that reached similar results for the global economy. Focused on the U.S. economy, the energy economists Jim Williams and Ryan Jones also reached a similar result, as part of the Zero Carbon Action Plan (ZCAP) project.¹⁰

From this and related evidence, I conclude that absolute decoupling is certainly a feasible, though also obviously a hugely challenging, project. But we can't just talk about it, pro or con. We have to make the investments, at 2.5 percent of global GDP per year or thereabouts, every year until 2050, to build the global clean energy economy. If we do that, absolute decoupling will happen. If we don't make those investments, then of course, absolute decoupling becomes an impossibility.

CJP: *Various ecologically-minded activists are also arguing that the Green New Deal relies on the use of massive energy resources, including extensive use of the steel industry, in order to make the transition to a clean, renewable, and net-zero emissions economy, and that what is really needed instead is a green revolution of the mind whereby zero energy living is the ultimate goal. My question is this: can the Green New Deal deliver 100 percent clean energy?*

RP: There are several industries in which energy is consumed intensively. They include steel, cement, and paper, along with, obviously, all forms of transportation. But note that these industries are energy intensive. They are not necessarily fossil fuel energy intensive. If we succeed, through the Green New Deal, in increasing the efficiency at which these industries consume energy and we also deliver abundant supplies of clean renewable energy, then the problems of dealing with energy-intensive industries can be solved. It's true that there will be some specific areas which will present more difficult challenges. For example, some parts of steel production rely on furnaces that are operating at very high temperatures. Reaching these high temperatures are, to date, difficult to achieve through electricity as opposed to burning coal in a furnace. This problem will need to be solved over time. One likely solution could be to rely on laser technology through which the required high temperatures can be reached with electricity, with the electricity, in turn, being produced through renewable energy.

Another more difficult area is long-distance aviation. To date, we cannot rely on electric batteries to fly planes across the Atlantic Ocean, for example, as we can to drive cars from New York to California. One likely solution here will be to fuel the planes' engines with low-emissions liquid bioenergy, such as ethanol produced from agricultural wastes as the raw material. Battery storage capacities are also likely to be improving significantly with more people focusing on solving exactly this problem.¹¹ Let's remember that the costs of producing electricity from solar photovoltaic panels have fallen by over 80 percent within the past nine years, and the U.S. Energy Department itself projects further major declines in just the next five years.¹² Moreover, the International Renewable Agency reported just a week ago that, for the first time, 62 percent of all renewable energy sources produced energy at lower costs than the cheapest sources of fossil fuel energy.¹³

All of this tells me that achieving absolute decoupling is a feasible project within the framework of a global Green New Deal. The Green New Deal, in turn, is, in my view, the only way through which climate stabilization can become fully consistent with expanding decent work opportunities, raising mass living standards, and fighting poverty in all regions of the world.

ROBERT POLLIN'S 2ND ARTICLE

A Green New Deal Program for California

CJP: *California has been at the forefront of the climate fight for years now, but the truth of the matter is that its efforts have been falling short. Now, you and some colleagues of yours at the Political Economy Research Institute (PERI) of the University of Massachusetts at Amherst have just completed a commissioned climate stabilization project for California that can also serve as an engine for economic recovery as well as expanding economic opportunities across the state. In a nutshell, how does the project envision the clean energy transition to take place in a manner consistent with the emission targets set out by the Intergovernmental Panel on Climate Change (IPCC) in 2018, and how will it be financed?*

RP: This study presents a recovery program for California that will also build a durable foundation for an economically robust and ecologically sustainable longer-term growth trajectory. California has long been a national and global leader in implementing robust climate stabilization policies. This includes the 2018 Executive Order B-55-18 by then Governor Jerry Brown. This measure committed the state to cut CO₂ emissions in the state by 50 percent as of 2030, to become carbon neutral no later than 2045 and to produce net negative emissions thereafter. These goals are somewhat more ambitious than those set out by the IPCC in 2018. Our study outlines a program through which the state can achieve its own established goals.

Our study shows how these 2030 and 2045 emissions reduction targets can be accomplished in California through phasing out the consumption of oil, coal, and natural gas to generate energy in the state, since burning fossil fuels to produce energy is, by far, the primary source of CO₂ emissions, and thereby, the single greatest factor causing climate change. The project we propose is to build a clean energy infrastructure to replace the existing fossil fuel-dominant infrastructure. The clean energy infrastructure will require large-scale investments to, first, dramatically raise energy efficiency standards in the state and, second, to equally dramatically expand the supply of clean renewable energy supplies, including solar and wind primarily, with supplemental supplies from low-emissions bioenergy, geothermal and small-scale hydro power. We show how this climate stabilization program for California can also serve as a major new engine of job creation and economic well-being throughout the state, both in the short- and longer run.

We have scaled the clean energy investment project at about \$76 billion per year on average between 2021–2030. This would equal roughly 2 percent of what we estimate will be the state's average GDP between 2021–2030. In other words, California can hit its emissions reduction targets through maintaining clean energy investment spending levels at about 2 percent of overall economic activity in the state. That means that roughly 98 percent of the state's annual economic activity can still be focused on anything other than clean energy investments. But the state must maintain this 2 percent of GDP investment level in clean energy for the program to work.

We estimate this level of investment will generate roughly 420,000 jobs throughout the state's economy. New job opportunities will open for, among other occupations, carpenters, machinists, welders, electronic equipment assemblers, environmental scientists, administrative assistants, accountants, truck drivers, roofers and agricultural laborers. Investments in public transportation—a major component of the energy efficiency investment program—will produce public-sector jobs for drivers and managerial staff. The quality of these jobs—including wages, benefits, and levels of unionization—vary by sector. In general, it will be critical to raise job quality standards as the number of jobs available expands. Raising unionization rates, as well as expanding job training programs will all be crucial for raising overall job quality levels. Local hire provisions and related measures will also need to be implemented to ensure equitable access by race and gender to the expanding job opportunities.

While focusing on the clean energy investment to reduce California's CO₂ emissions by 50 percent as of 2030, our study does also examine how the state can achieve its longer-term goal of becoming a zero-emissions economy by 2045. The basic features of the investment program between 2031–2045 can be extended from the 2021–2030 framework. But, in fact, the scale of the investment spending required to achieve the 2045 zero-emissions target can be somewhat more modest, averaging about 1.3 percent of the state's GDP between 2031–2045.

Our study also examines a complementary investment project to upgrade California's economy base through manufacturing, infrastructure, land restoration and agriculture investments. We budgeted this program at about \$62 billion per year, or 1.7 percent of the state's GDP—in these areas. This investment program is based on the proposed national THRIVE Agenda, a bill introduced into the U.S. Congress in February 2021 by Senator Edward Markey and Congresswoman Debbie Dingell to “Transform, Heal, and Renew by Investing in a Vibrant Economy.” To date, the THRIVE Agenda has been endorsed by more than 100 members of Congress and hundreds of major union, racial justice and climate organizations. We estimate that these investments will generate about 626,000 jobs throughout the state, in a wide range of occupations.

When we bring together the combined investment programs in the areas of energy efficiency and renewable energy, along with public infrastructure/manufacturing and land restoration/agriculture, total spending in California comes to an average of about \$140 billion per year, equal to a bit less than 4 percent of California's average annual GDP between 2021–2030. This level of job creation would generate about 1 million jobs within California. This higher level of job creation will then be sustained through the full decade, as long as the budgetary levels for the range of investment programs are maintained. The expansion in job opportunities will equal more than 5 percent of California's 2019 labor force. This means that, if California's unemployment rate was, say, 7 percent without this combined investment program, these investments could drive unemployment to something in the range of 2 percent—i.e. to reach something close to full employment in the state.

An absolute front-and-center feature of our proposal is the just transition program for the state's fossil fuel-dependent workers and communities. About 112,000 people are employed in California in fossil fuel-based industries, amounting to about

0.6 percent the state's total workforce in 2019. Workers in the state's fossil fuel-based industries will, of course, experience job losses as the state dramatically reduces consumption of these CO₂-generating energy sources. We estimate that about 3,200 workers per year will be displaced in these industries in California between 2021–2030 while another roughly 2,500 will voluntarily retire each year. It is critical that all of these workers receive pension guarantees, health care coverage, re-employment guarantees along with wage subsidies to insure they will not experience income losses, along with retraining and relocation support, as needed. Enacting a generous just transition program for the displaced fossil fuel-based industry workers is especially important. We estimate that the costs of a generous just transition package for all fossil fuel industry-based workers experiencing layoffs would come to about \$470 million per year. This is equal to about 0.02 percent (two one-hundredths of one percent) of the state's average GDP between 2021–2030.

Three counties in California—Kern, Contra Costa, and Los Angeles—account for roughly half of all employment in the state's fossil fuel-based industries. Kern County, in particular, will face the most significant proportional impacts from the phase-down of the state's fossil fuel industries. We therefore present a focused discussion on providing community transition support for Kern County. In fact, we found that some initial-stage activities are already underway in Kern to move the area away from its current level of fossil fuel-based industry dependency and to build there a clean energy production infrastructure.

How do you pay for the whole thing? It's actually straightforward, especially as we keep in mind that, overall, we are talking about devoting less than 4 percent of the state's overall economic activity to these investment projects, and the most critical purpose of these projects is, after all, just to achieve the state's own CO₂ emissions reduction targets. Of the roughly \$140 billion per year in combined investments and the just transition program, we assume that roughly half of total spending, about \$70 billion per year, will be provided by private investors, while the other half is supplied by public spending. Private investments in the clean energy areas in particular will be incentivized by the federal and statewide regulatory environment. A significant share, if not the majority of the approximately \$70 billion per year in public spending is likely to come from a version of the Biden Administration's proposed American Jobs Plan, which is focused on infrastructure and clean energy investments. The State of California could then provide the additional funding, as needed. The fact that the state can borrow at very low interest rates now is critical. As an example, we show that if the state government issues \$30 billion in bonds in the current low-interest rate environment, the debt servicing burden will also be low, i.e. in the range of 0.3 percent of the state's annual general revenues. It follows that even if the federal government's funding through the final version of the Biden American Jobs Plan comes in at a relatively low figure, the State of California could still provide the additional financing through issuing bonds in the current low-interest rate environment without imposing a major burden on the state's overall budget.

CJP: *The project has already been endorsed by 19 unions across the state of California, and more are expected to join. This is undoubtedly a highly significant development, but, given that only*

around 16 percent of the total workforce is unionized, isn't there a need to reach out to the rest of the population for support?

RP: For decades now, wide majorities of people in California have already been supportive of strong measures to protect the environment and combat climate change. Increasingly also, the state is suffering disproportionately from the effects of climate change and, more generally, from burning fossil fuels to produce energy, including wildfires, droughts, floods, heat waves, and air pollution that are all becoming more severe over time. The National Oceanic and Atmospheric Administration estimates that, just since 2013, California has experienced roughly 16 “billion-dollar disaster events,” generating economic losses of over \$100 billion in total. Beyond these climate-specific considerations, it is also the case that the clean energy investment program will deliver lower energy costs to all consumers in California. This is, first, because raising energy efficiency standards will enable consumers to spend less money for a given amount of energy services—e.g. to heat, cool, and light homes, or to drive from Riverside to LA. In addition, the costs of wind, solar, and geothermal power are all roughly equal to or lower than those for fossil fuels and nuclear energy, and are falling significantly. As such, the average California household should be able to save nearly 40 percent on their overall annual energy bill relative to what they spend now in the current fossil-fuel dominant system. In short, everyone in the state has a personal stake in solving the climate crisis, even those who aren't particularly concerned with the most fundamental matter of saving the planet.

CJP: *Can you also speak about the national implications set by the union support in California for the climate stabilization project you and your colleagues have designed?*

RP: The union movement has increasingly embraced a major leadership role in advancing green transition programs. I have worked with the leadership of the AFL-CIO on these issues in multiple states. The level at which California unions have supported our study is one major step forward, and I am, of course, extremely pleased by this support. But it is also part of a growing trend that has been advancing due to the work of outstanding, committed organizers throughout the country. When I first started working on these issues 14 years ago, the prevailing view in mainstream circles—not the labor movement, but in the circles of high-powered policymakers, academia and the mainstream press—was that there is an huge and unavoidable tradeoff between jobs and the environment. You could have one or the other—more jobs or a cleaner environment. But you can't have both, so choose one. Over the last decade, lots of very effective labor movement activists—from the grassroots levels to many top officials—have pounded home the reality that this is a false trade-off. Due to their efforts, this message has now penetrated all the way up to the Biden Administration. Note that Biden is calling his clean energy program an “American Jobs Plan.”

CJP: *This is really highly encouraging news in the battle to tame global warming, so I must ask: What's next in line in terms of your climate stabilization projects?*

RP: My co-workers and I at PERI are continuing to work with different groups to advance robust climate programs at the national, state as well as county and commu-

nity levels. Separately, I am working on green transition studies for other countries, Greece being one of them. In the case of Greece, I am looking forward to working more on the issue of land-use requirements in building a green energy infrastructure, building from the outstanding work on this question by the Harvard physicist Mara Prentiss. The issue here is: do we really have to locate wind turbines on top of the most beautiful pristine mountain cites in Greece in order to build a green economy? This is another one of the false trade-offs that lots of people in power want us to believe. I am also working on issues of financing the global Green New Deal in developing and middle-income countries, especially in Asia, in conjunction with the United Nations Conference on Trade and Development (UNCTAD). That, in addition to trying to maintain the solar panels at my house and office reasonably well.

DON FITZ'S RESPONSE

Be Careful What Energy You Wish For

Climate change is an existential problem confronting humanity and Robert Pollin offers well thought-out plans in his [first](#) and [second](#) articles. There is only space here to respond to these themes: (1) We can reach zero CO₂ emissions by 2050; (2) An enormous expansion of alternative energy (AltE) can create far more jobs than would be lost by eliminating fossil fuels (FF); and (3) Without stating so explicitly, he implies that negative aspects of AltE would be tiny.

Unfortunately, the downsides of AltE loom so large that they must form the core of any serious discussion. Like many proponents of AltE, Pollin does not present climate change as symptomatic of capitalist overproduction, but as a stand-alone crisis whose resolution may require strengthening capitalism. Yet, there is already more than enough manufactured production to meet the needs of humanity, if only manufacturing were shifted from creating what is wasteful and destructive to production for need.

The rush to massively expand AltE ignores what environmentalists have known for decades. Redesigning cities to create walkable communities is vastly more ecological than subjecting children in the Democratic Republic of Congo to the [horrors of cobalt mining](#) for electric vehicles. Humanity can reduce its footprint by consuming much less meat and relying on local food rather than transporting the average bite 1700 miles. Americans do not need housing space vastly exceeding that of anywhere else in the world (except Australia). Buildings can be altered for reuse instead of constant tear-down-rebuilding. Manufacturing standards can be set to require the maximum life for goods rather than subjecting people to the message of “Buy, Buy, Buy!” as corporations design products to fall apart and go out of style. Humanity does not need more crap—corporations do.

Rather than exploring these, Pollin labors to satisfy the corporate urge for infinite growth via “clean, renewable” energy sources of solar, wind, “small-scale hydro,” and “low-emissions bioenergy.” It is also necessary to point out that achieving a “zero emissions economy” by 2050 is a disingenuous goal. The life cycle of AltE requires FFs for construction equipment, mining for essential minerals, transportation, and

disposing of the energy harvesting equipment. Wind and solar are intermittent, which means they require backup (often gas) for emergencies.

Solar power. In addition to health problems from extraction, manufacturing and disposal, there are issues of those who would be affected. Greg Wagner recently wrote me:

“I live in a small rural farming community known as Goldendale, Washington in Klickitat County on the east side of the state. I formed the group Citizens Educated about Solar Energy (CEASE) when I learned by accident the solar companies’ plans. My home and many others are surrounded by tens of thousands of acres of wheat/alfalfa/hay fields and beautiful views of Mt. Adams, Mt. St. Helens and Mt. Hood. This will all be destroyed if our county commissioners allow Invenergy and Cypress Creek Renewables to build their proposed solar sites on the 10,000 acres we know about...”

On the other side of the US, [citizens in Culpepper County, Virginia](#) blocked a proposal by Maroon Solar. The planning board said that “the project was out of character with the area, too large, and would be injurious to the health and safety of area residents.” Opponents also commented that “the utility-scale project would ruin the rural nature of the area, the environment and historic resources.”

Wind power. Health problems also appear with wind and victims of its placement are often unhappy. Opponents halted wind turbines in [Reno County, Kansas](#). As in other areas, a major concern was having wind turbines too close to people. As Patrick Richardson reported, “The setback is often no more than double—sometimes just one and a half times—blade height, meaning turbines can be within as little as 500 feet away from a school, as in Labette County.”

Showing that the problem is international, Shivani Gupta writes of 1000 villagers in the [Kachchh district of India](#) who protested plans to put industrial wind turbines in portions of the Sangnara forest and adjacent common grazing areas where farmers bring their cows and sheep. “The Sangnara forest is home to a huge diversity of endangered flora and fauna. This includes chinkara, wolf, caracal, ratel, hyena, desert cat, Indian fox, spiny tailed lizard, desert monitor, white-naped tit, vultures, and many more.”

“Small scale” hydro. Such power comes from dams with a [capacity of less than 30 MW](#). While these dams are individually less destructive than mega-dams, a much, much larger number would be needed to provide power for an incessantly growing capitalism.

At 22 MW capacity, the [Agua Zarca hydro-project in Honduras](#) was “small-scale.” Berta Cáceres won the 2015 Goldman Environmental Prize for organizing the Lenca people along with other indigenous groups and the Afro-Honduran Garifunas to oppose the dam. The following year she was murdered by those who stood to profit from “[clean, renewable energy](#).” In addition to being sacred, “the [Gualcarque River](#) is a primary source of water for them to grow their food and harvest medicinal plants. Dams can flood fertile plains and deprive communities of water for livestock and crops.”

“Low-emissions” bioenergy. Burning organic material is now the rage in Europe. In April 2021, climate scientists [James Dyke](#), [Robert Watson](#), and [Wolfgang Knorr](#), who had formerly supported plans for “net-zero” emissions did an about-face as they wrote about its latest version, Bioenergy Carbon Capture and Storage, or BECCS:

“... rather than allow ecosystems to recover from human impacts and forests to regrow, BECCS generally refers to dedicated industrial-scale plantations regularly harvested for bioenergy rather than carbon stored away in forest trunks, roots and soils. Currently, the two most efficient biofuels are sugarcane for bioethanol and palm oil for biodiesel—both grown in the tropics. Endless rows of such fast growing monoculture trees or other bioenergy crops harvested at frequent intervals devastate biodiversity. It has been estimated that BECCS would demand between 0.4 and 1.2 billion hectares of land. That’s 25% to 80% of all the land currently under cultivation.”

BECCS can also include burning wood pellets. [Land Institute research scientist Stan Cox](#) observes that “This process is not emissions-free; in fact, wood-fired power plants produce more pollution per kilowatt-hour of electricity than coal-fired plants.” Even if BECCS were used to capture those emissions, Cox notes that, “... the process’s many steps—producing and harvesting biomass crops, hauling the biomass to the processing factory, grinding and pelletizing, hauling pellets to the power plant, sucking carbon dioxide out of the smokestack, liquefying the carbon dioxide, hauling the liquid to the injection field, and shooting it into the earth under high pressure—would, in sum, eat up large quantities of energy.”

Jobs. Once we realize both that AltE has devastating consequences and that humanity can exist quite well without the unnecessary production, a critically important question remains: Will using much less energy leave tens of millions of people unemployed? After all, ensuring full employment during a just economic transition must be a central goal of coping with climate disaster. The answer is provided to us by centuries of labor activists who have demanded a shorter work week. FDR was president the last time that labor considered a 30 hour work week in the US. Why in the world should we work more hours to destroy the lives of our descendants?

Caps. One of the most astounding aspects of the Green New Deal (GND) is that, despite understanding by its supporters that FFs must be reduced, none of the Democratic Party versions of the GND include a cap on the amount of FFs that can be produced. They imply that increasing AltE will cause FF use to decline, which is completely false. The capitalist state will ensure that AltE is added to the mix. As Cox notes succinctly: “The [purge of oil, gas, and coal](#) must be done directly, by law.”

Questions. Given that dangers of AltE are real, large, and growing, these are questions that its adherents should answer:

1. Do they acknowledge that the intermittency of solar and wind power requires FF backup and that FFs are required for mining (extraction), material and waste transportation, construction, operation and disposal, meaning that zero FF usage is unrealistic?

2. If they recognize that AltE is thick with health and environmental problems throughout its life cycle, do they agree that it should not be described as “clean?”

3. Knowing that Bernie Sanders and the Democratic Party “Squad” do not call for limits on producing and burning FFs, do they part company with them in calling for caps to be quantified for specific dates?

Contradictions. Jonathan Cook realizes that “it is quite possible—common, in fact—for us to hold contradictory beliefs at the same time: like worrying about the threat posed to our children’s future from climate change, while [supporting political systems committed](#) to building more roads and runways.” An increasing number of people are overcoming this psychological dilemma as they realize the fallacy of “solutions” that intensify problems. Circular destruction occurs when hotter weather leads to more air conditioning, which causes more energy production for electricity, which causes more climate change and increased heat. It cannot be said too many times: the fundamental challenge today is to reduce production while increasing the quality of life. This capitalist crisis of overproduction cannot possibly be solved by increasing production.

ROBERT POLLIN’S RESPONSE

Response to Don Fitz

Don Fitz’s response to my two interviews that Z generously republished makes two major assertions: 1) Reducing overall consumption and working fewer hours provides a viable path on its own to stabilizing the global climate; and 2) Renewable energy sources, such as solar and wind power, are not really “clean” even though they supply energy without generating CO₂ emissions. I will address these in turn.

As I state at the outset of my first posted interview, on “degrowth,” I strongly agree that “a significant share of what is produced and consumed in the current global capitalist economy is wasteful, especially much, if not most, of what high-income people throughout the world consume.” Fitz is merely setting up a straw-person in suggesting that I think otherwise.

More pertinently, Fitz seems to believe that we can move the global economy onto a viable climate stabilization path if we all consume less, work fewer hours, and eat less meat, while also shortening global supply chains and making cities more walkable. This appears to be the case, in his view, even if we do not transform our global energy system from one dominated by fossil fuels to one dominated by sources that are CO₂-emissions free. He offers no evidence to support his position. In fact, there is no evidence that supports his position.

To get into some specifics: the world economy emitted about 34 billion tons of CO₂ into the atmosphere as of the most recent 2018 data. Most of these emissions result through burning oil, coal and natural gas to produce energy. The IPCC has

said that we need to cut these emissions from burning fossil fuels by about 50 percent as of 2030—only a little more than 8 years from now—and to be at net zero emissions by 2050.

I myself have always strongly emphasized, including in both the interviews posted at Z, the centrality of investments to raise energy efficiency standards throughout the world. That means, among other things, significantly upgrading the heating, lighting, cooling, and insulation equipment in buildings, greatly expanding public transportation systems, and producing much more efficient private vehicles. However, even if we make these critical investments to raise efficiency standards, at best we will be able to reduce global energy consumption in the range of 5–10 percent. This assumes, as I said in the degrowth interview, that “people are still going to need to consume energy to light, heat and cool buildings, to power cars, buses, trains, and airplanes and to operate computers and industrial machinery, among other uses.”

In particular, I strongly favor, as part of any minimally decent global egalitarian program, a significant increase in access to energy for lower-income people in all regions, to enable them to raise their living standards. I do not think that Fitz’s claim that “humanity does not need more crap” applies to the roughly [70 percent of the world’s population](#)—5.5 billion people—that lives on [less than \\$10 a day](#). It is critical to be able to provide, for example, warm, well-lit living spaces, high-quality public transportation, and access to the internet as efficiently as possible for this overwhelming majority of humanity.

Fitz appears to believe, without providing evidence, that we can cut global energy consumption by far more than 5–10 percent without cutting the living standards of low-income people. But let’s note that even if we were to cut global energy consumption by, for example, an implausible 50 percent by consuming “less crap” and working fewer hours, we would still be only half way to bringing CO₂ emissions down to zero, as long as we maintain intact our current fossil fuel-dominant energy infrastructure.

In short, there is simply no getting around the fact that we need to supplant our existing fossil-fuel dominant energy system that is the main cause of the global climate crisis with an alternative system that delivers abundant energy without generating CO₂ emissions. This is where renewable energy becomes critical. Of course, there are significant challenges to address in building out a global renewable-dominant energy system. But none of these challenges are insurmountable, as Fitz suggests. For example, Fitz cites the obvious matter of intermittency with solar and wind power—that the sun isn’t always shining and the wind isn’t always blowing at any given location. But this problem can be solved through continuing to make advances in battery storage and electricity transmission systems. It is also the case that other renewable sources—geothermal, hydro and low-emissions bioenergy—are not intermittent. They can serve as supplemental energy sources in combined renewable energy systems.

Fitz also asserts that building the renewable energy infrastructure can only be accomplished by consuming more fossil fuel energy. This is not true. As the supply of renewable energy expands, the full range of industrial machinery, transportation equipment and computers can all be powered through renewable energy sources just as well as if not better than, through fossil fuel energy.

Fitz cites examples of renewable energy projects being built in ways that disrupt communities and natural habitats. Such concerns are valid. The land-use issues around building a renewable energy infrastructure need to be addressed with great care and democratic decision-making. But as a general proposition, it is useful to start from the calculations of the Harvard University physicist [Mara Prentiss](#) that with the U.S. as a high-efficiency economy, more than half of this necessary surface area could be provided through locating [solar panels on rooftops](#) and parking lots throughout the country. Beyond this space provided by rooftops and parking lots, solar energy sources using existing technologies could supply 100 percent of U.S. energy demand while consuming somewhere between 0.1 and 0.2 percent of additional U.S. land area.

If Fitz is convinced that renewable energy unavoidably produces “devastating consequences,” then it is incumbent on him to present his superior alternative. Does he favor maintaining the existing fossil-fuel dominant system? Would he prefer a global transition to a nuclear-powered energy system? Does he think that having everyone consume “less crap” will wipe out most of the world’s demand for energy from any and all sources?

As a final note, I think it would be constructive if Fitz could restrain his rhetoric, along with filling in the major gaps in his analysis that I have noted here. For example, Fitz writes that I claim that the resolution of the climate crisis “may require strengthening capitalism.” Here is what I actually said at the end of the degrowth interview: “The Green New Deal... is, in my view, the only way through which climate stabilization can become fully consistent with expanding decent work opportunities, raising mass living standards, and fighting poverty in all regions of the world.” In this spirit, it is encouraging that 20 labor unions in California—including the state’s oil refinery workers’ union—endorsed the Green New Deal program for the state that I co-authored and describe in the second posted interview.

DON FITZ’S FINAL RESPONSE

Against Overproduction

Robert Pollin repeats a message often seen in writings defending alternative energy (AltE): while they briefly shake their heads at capitalist waste, they deny an overproduction problem. In his response to my article on “Be Careful What Energy You Wish For,” his message comes through that there are no limits on what can be done to the Earth’s ecosystems that AltE can’t solve.

He accuses me of intending to restrict “consumption” even though that word never appears in my article. What appears repeatedly is the word “production.” Capitalism produces for profit, not consumption. This seemingly small difference becomes central for environmental solutions. A liberal might say “Produce cars, but make people feel guilty about driving them.” A socialist would say “Create walkable communities as a precondition for limiting production of individually owned cars.”

As heat waves, out-of-control fires and hurricanes increasingly sweep the globe, fossil fuel (FF) apologists continue their “climate change denial.” They are matched

by the “energy denial” of AltE enthusiasts who similarly deny that ALL industrially produced energy has seriously negative effects.

The first major problem with Pollin’s rebuttal is that, like Congressional Democrats, he fails to demand federal legislation capping production of oil, gas and coal and lowering the caps to zero by specific dates. With no plan for eliminating FFs, we are left with a vague belief that increasing AltE will somehow cause a reduction in FFs rather than adding new sources of energy to the mix. To further confuse the issue, he claims that AltE has no emissions, when in fact every type of AltE produces significant emissions during its life cycle.

Second, by failing to acknowledge that AltE is not “clean,” he trivializes the way it destroys communities and ancestral lands, poisons workers, and intensifies species extinction during operation and decommissioning. One example is lithium for electric vehicles. As [Thea Riofrancos writes](#): “Chile’s Atacama Desert is on the water system... Mining for lithium here is like mining salty water and evaporating it. Already water-scarce, the region is becoming drier due to climate change and water use by extractive sectors...”

Lithium is then manufactured into batteries, exposing workers to [NMP](#) (reproductive toxin and embryotoxic), [acetone](#) (potential for neuroblastoma in children), and [biphenyl](#) (associated with Parkinson’s disease and dangers to the respiratory tract, liver and nervous system). Multiply these effects of lithium by other damaging effects and then multiply them by the hundreds or thousands of substances that are mined for AltE and you get an idea of the KNOWN dangers.

A third way in which Pollin exemplifies AltE writing is by vastly underestimating land area it requires by claiming that rooftops and parking lots provide most of the solution. Perhaps he did not read the quotation in my previous piece by climate scientists [James Dyke, Robert Watson, and Wolfgang Knorr](#) that harvesting wood for biomass energy “would demand between 0.4 and 1.2 billion hectares of land. That’s 25% to 80% of all the land currently under cultivation.”

And perhaps he has not seen the estimate of [Distinguished Professor Emeritus Vaclav Smil](#) that “To replace current US energy consumption with renewables, you’d need to devote at least 25–50 percent of the US landmass to solar, wind, and biofuels.” Additional points must be considered:

1. If Pollin truly believes that only a tiny land area is needed for AltE, then he should call for an end to lawsuits in the US and land grabs across the globe to build solar arrays and industrial wind turbines.
2. Since the US uses 25% of the world’s energy with only 6% of its population, an unbelievable amount of land and rivers would be required for the rest of the world to match US squandering of resources.
3. A 3% annual growth rate in GDP means a doubling of the economy in less than 25 years, a quadrupling of energy usage in less than 50 years, and an 8-fold increase in less than 75 years.

4. The Law of Diminishing Returns verifies that the best space for wind, solar, hydro and biomass are used first and remaining land/rivers are less productive, requiring more to be used over time.

This means that land usage must expand much more rapidly than GDP, exhausting the Earth's resources and species.

A fourth error permeating AltE writing is faith in unproven technologies. Pollin expects improvements in "industrial machinery, transportation equipment and computers" along with "advances in battery storage and electricity transmission systems." Such promises of accomplishments in an imagined future remind me that, during the '50s, the nuclear industry painted rosy pictures of "electricity too cheap to meter" which were just around the corner.

Like other AltE supporters, Pollin insists that production must be increased massively to provide for the world's poor. It is helpful to examine Cuba during its "Special Period" after the USSR collapsed in 1991 and discontinued its \$4-5 billion annual subsidy. In my 2020 book, [Cuban Health Care: The Ongoing Revolution](#), I emphasize that Cuba's poverty is exacerbated by the embargo of 60 years from the richest country in the world, the US. During the Special Period, Cuba's economy shrunk by 45%, imports fell from \$8.12 billion to \$1.99 billion, and oil imports from Russia plunged from 13.3 to 1.8 million tons.

Despite these traumas, Cuba actually improved its health care system. In 1990, infant mortality per 1000 live births were 10.5 in Cuba and 9.4 in the US. By the end of the Special Period in 2000, Cuba was doing better with 6.3 deaths versus 7.1 in the US. At the beginning of the Special Period Cubans expected to live 64.2 years and Americans to live 69.8 years. By 2000, Cuba's life expectancy of 76.9 years slightly edged out that of the US at 76.8 years.

This is vitally important for a discussion of energy: Cuba spends roughly 10% per person per year on health care compared to the US. How is this possible? Even with an end to the embargo and ultra-economic growth, Cuba would not have been able to outpace per capita GDP of the US.

The fundamental precondition of those changes was creating a new consciousness that Cuba could accomplish much more with much less. Without that new consciousness, its medical miracle could never have happened.

Tunnel-visioning on AltE blocks the consciousness necessary for developing ways to use vastly less energy, which is essential for protecting biodiversity and human health. The gargantuan increase in production that a new AltE system would require is vital to capitalism, which cannot tolerate a long-term decrease in production. Capitalism is doomed to perish unless it finds a way to grow without FFs. Thus, late capitalism desperately needs an ideology to justify AltE growth, just as infant capitalism needed the ideology of racism to justify plunder of Africa, Asian and the Americas.

During World War I, many Social Democrats took sides with "their own" national capitalists, believing that they were less bad. Today, their political great-grandchildren similarly help to preserve capitalism by siding with AltE "progressive capitalists." Environmental, labor and socialist movements should reject any ideology of plundering of the Earth to fund capitalism's pathological urge to grow. It is time to scream DEFUND CAPITALISM!

"The two efforts—averting environmental disaster, dismantling capitalism in favor of a more free and just and democratic society—should and can proceed in parallel... [like] Tony Mazzocchi's [a late 20th-century US labor leader] efforts to forge a labor coalition that would not only challenge owner-management control of the workplace but also be in the forefront of the environmental movement."

—Noam Chomsky, *Climate Crisis and the Global Green New Deal*

Endnotes for 'Labor Unions Rally Behind California's Zero-Emissions Climate Plan'

- 1 <https://vocabulary.degrowth.org/>
- 2 <https://www.sciencedirect.com/science/article/abs/pii/S0921800919319615>
- 3 Herman Daly, "Ecologies of Scale: Interview by Benjamin Kunkel," NLR 109, January-February 2018, pp. 81 – 104.
- 4 <https://www.imf.org/en/Publications/WEO/Issues/2021/01/26/2021-world-economic-outlook-update>
- 5 <https://www.nature.com/articles/d41586-021-00090-3>
- 6 <http://www.wri.org/blog/2016/04/roads-decoupling-21-countries-are-reducing-carbon-emissions-while-growing-gdp>
- 7 <https://www.versobooks.com/books/3239-climate-crisis-and-the-global-green-new-deal>
- 8 https://www.irena.org/-/media/Files/IRENA/Agency/Publication/2021/March/IRENA_World_Energy_Transitions_Outlook_2021.pdf
- 9 <https://www.iea.org/reports/net-zero-by-2050>
- 10 <https://www.unsdsn.org/Zero-Carbon-Action-Plan>
- 11 https://www.canarymedia.com/articles/ess-is-betting-the-world-is-ready-for-a-billion-dollar-battery-disrupter/?utm_campaign=canary&utm_medium=email&_hsmi=136073242&_hsenc=p2ANqtz-801DVHT_PclLpL-SXYX9ohRWgAOGVkvfDwpH4ez2pL-77FMsaXaOfTTc9GEv33jbg1_4DiQwp24ykoiPM-ug1514gg&utm_source=newsletter
- 12 https://www.eia.gov/outlooks/aeo/pdf/electricity_generation.pdf
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Guantanamo Past the Point of All Shame

DAVID SWANSON

U.S. high schools should teach courses on Guantanamo: what not to do in the world, how not to make it even worse, and how not to compound that catastrophe beyond all shame and recovery.

As we tear down Confederate statues and continue brutalizing victims in Guantanamo, I wonder if in 2181, had Hollywood still been around, it would have made movies from the perspective of Guantanamo's prisoners while the U.S. government committed new and different atrocities to be bravely confronted in 2341.

That is to say, when will people learn that the problem is cruelty, not the particular flavor of cruelty?

The purpose of the Guantanamo prisons was and is cruelty and sadism. Names like Geoffrey Miller and Michael Bumgarner should become permanent synonyms for the twisted dehumanizing of victims in cages. The war is supposedly over, making it difficult for aging men who were innocent boys to "return" to the "battlefield" if freed from the Hell on Earth stolen from Cuba, but nothing ever made sense. We're on President #3 since promises were first made to shut Guantanamo down, yet it moans and rattles on, brutalizing its victims and their captors.

Don't Forget Us Here is the title of Mansoor Adayfi's book about his life from age 19 to age 33, which he spent in Guantanamo. He could not be seen as the youngster he was when first kidnapped and tortured, and was seen instead—or at least the pretense was made—that he was an important top anti-U.S. terrorist. That didn't require seeing him as a human being, quite the opposite. Nor did it have to make any sense. There was never any evidence that Adayfi was the person he was accused of being. Some of his imprisoners told him they knew it was false. He was never charged with any crime. But at some point, the U.S. government decided to pretend he was a different top terrorism commander, despite the lack of any evidence for that one either, or any explanation of how they could have captured such a person accidentally while imagining that he was someone else.

Adayfi's account begins like so many others. He was abused by the CIA in Afghanistan first: hung from a ceiling in the dark, naked, beaten, electrocuted. Then he was stuck into a cage in Guantanamo, having no idea what part of the Earth he was in or why. He only knew the guards behaved like lunatics, freaking out and screaming in a language he couldn't speak. The other prisoners spoke a variety of languages and had no reason to trust each other. The better guards were awful, and the Red Cross was worse. There seemed to be no rights, except for the iguanas.

At any opportunity, guards stormed in and beat prisoners, or dragged them off for torture/interrogation or solitary confinement. They deprived them of food, water, healthcare, or shelter from the sun. They stripped them and "cavity-searched" them. They mocked them and their religion.

But Adayfi's account develops into one of fighting back, of organizing and rallying the prisoners into all variety of resistance, violent and otherwise. Some hint of this appears early on in his atypical reaction to the usual threat to bring his mother there and rape her. Adayfi laughed at that threat, confident that his mother could whip the guards into shape.

The purpose of the Guantanamo prisons was and is cruelty and sadism. Names like Geoffrey Miller and Michael Bumgarner should become permanent synonyms for the twisted dehumanizing of victims in cages.

One of the main tools available and used was the hunger strike. Adayfi was force-fed for years. Other tactics included refusing to come out of a cage, refusing to answer endless ridiculous questions, destroying everything in a cage, inventing outrageous confessions of terrorist activity for days of interrogations and then pointing out that it was all made-up nonsense, making noise, and splashing guards with water, urine, or feces.

The people running the place chose to treat the prisoners as subhuman beasts, and did a pretty good job of making the prisoners play the part. The guards and interrogators would believe almost anything: that the prisoners had secret weapons or a radio network or had each been a top ally of Osama bin Laden—anything other than that they were innocent. The relentless interrogation—the slaps, the kicks, the broken ribs and teeth, the freezing, the stress positions, the noise machines, the lights—would go on until you admitted being whoever they said you were, but then you'd be in for it bad if you didn't know lots of details about this unknown person.

We know that some of the guards really thought all the prisoners were crazed murderers, because sometimes they'd play a trick on a new guard who fell asleep and put a prisoner near him when he awoke. The result was sheer panic. But we also know it was a choice to view a 19-year-old as a top general. It was a choice to suppose that after years and years of "Where is Bin Laden?" any answer that actually existed would still be relevant. It was a choice to use violence. We know it was a choice to use violence because of an extensive multi-year experiment in three acts.

In Act I, the prison treated its victims as monsters, torturing, strip-searching, routinely beating, depriving of food, etc., even while trying to bribe prisoners to spy on each other. And the result was often-violent resistance. One means that sometimes worked for Adayfi to lessen some injury was to beg for it like Brer Rabbit. Only by professing his deep desire to be kept near screaming loud vacuum cleaners put there, not to clean, but to make so much noise around the clock that one couldn't talk or think, did he get a break away from them.

The prisoners organized and plotted. They raised hell until interrogators stopped torturing one of their number. They jointly lured General Miller into position before hitting him in the face with shit and urine. They smashed their cages, ripped out the toilets, and showed how they could escape through the hole in the floor. They went on mass hunger strike. They gave the U.S. military vastly more work—but then, is that something the military didn't want?

Adayfi went six years without communication with his family. He became such an enemy of his torturers that he wrote a statement praising the crimes of 9/11 and promising to fight the U.S. if he got out.

In Act 2, after Barack Obama became president promising to close Guantanamo but didn't close it, Adayfi was permitted a lawyer. The lawyer treated him as a human being—but only after being horrified to meet him and not believing he was meeting the right person; Adayfi did not match his description as the very worst of the worst.

And the prison changed. It became basically a standard prison, which was such a step up that prisoners cried for joy. They were allowed into common spaces to sit and talk to each other. They were allowed books and televisions and cardboard scraps for art projects. They were allowed to study, and to go outside into a recreational area with the sky visible. And the result was that they didn't have to fight and resist and get beaten all the time. The sadists among the guards had very little left to do. Adayfi learned English and business and art. Prisoners and guards struck up friendships.

In Act 3, in response to nothing, apparently due to a change in command, old rules and brutality were reintroduced, and the prisoners responded as before, back on hunger strike, and when intentionally provoked by damaging Qur'ans, back to violence. The guards destroyed all the art projects the prisoners had made. And the U.S. government offered to let Adayfi go if he would dishonestly testify in court against another prisoner. He refused.

When Mansoor Adayfi was finally freed, it was with no apology, except unofficially from a Colonel who admitted to knowing his innocence, and he was freed by forcing him to a place he did not know, Serbia, gagged, blindfolded, hooded, earmuffed, and shackled. Nothing had been learned, as the purpose of the whole enterprise had included from the start the avoidance of learning anything.

This piece first appeared in World BEYOND War (<https://worldbeyondwar.org/guantanamo-past-the-point-of-all-shame/>) on Sept. 9, 2021.

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Decolonizing Minds, Including My Own, About U.S. Capitalist State Settler Colonialism

GARY OLSON

"The discovery of gold and silver in America, the extirpation, enslavement and entombment in mines of the aboriginal population, the beginning of the conquest and looting of the East Indies, the turning of Africa into a warren for the hunting of black skins, signaled the rosy dawn of the era of capitalist production. These idyllic proceedings are the chief moments of primitive accumulation. On their heels tread the commercial wars of the European nations, with the globe for a theatre"¹ — Karl Marx

"The first fact of the history of American immigration is genocide: the displacement and destruction of the Native people of North America. This is part of the story of immigration, it is not some other, parallel history."² — Paul Spickard

"Through the centuries, the Republic that eventuated in North America has maintained a maximum of chutzpah and a minimum of awareness in forging a creation myth that sees slavery and dispossession not as foundational but as inimical to the founding of the nation now known as the United States. But, of course, to confront the ugly reality would induce a persistent sleeplessness interrupted by haunted dreams, so thus far this unsteadiness has prevailed."³ — Gerard Horne

Destitute Peasants Leave Norway for the American Frontier

On April 21, 1885, a steamship left Christiana (now, Oslo) Norway for Liverpool, England and then on to a 9-day voyage for North America. Among the ship's 1500 passengers, most of them in steerage, which meant below the water line, no windows and only scant light and ventilation, was the recently widowed Elizabeth Thorson and her five children. The youngest was ten-year-old Emma who would become my grandmother. Elizabeth's decision to emigrate was an act of awe-inspiring courage and resolve even though she had more than ample reason to fear for her family's future if she remained in Norway and realized that the American frontier was her only option.

There is insufficient space to detail Norway's rigid social order that allowed no opportunity for advancement. Suffice it here to say that the apex of the class system consisted of an aristocracy of professional men who controlled the economy and the government. Their rule included the hierarchy of the powerful and reactionary Norwegian state Lutheran church for which it was unlawful not to be a member.

Due to topographical dictates, only 3 percent of the land was tillable and most of that was held by the King (the "King's Commons"), the church and other large landowners. Property relations were such that the vast majority of rural folk were landless. Although some resistance sprang up in the 1850s, it was easily crushed by the state's large-scale police action.

Some 85 percent of the population was rural, consisting of small farmers, cotters (poor tenants) and servants. However, unlike the English feudal dispossession of the peasants from their land and replacement of them with sheep which occurred in the sixteenth century in what became known as the enclosure movement, Norwegian peasants lacked even the option of selling their labor to toil in factories under debasing Dickensian conditions.

In 1825, the first organized emigration of Norwegians occurred when a small group of religious dissidents, many of them Quakers, departed from Norway on the sloop Restauration and after a hazardous three-month crossing landed in New York harbor, most of them eventually settling in rural New York state. In the 1840s, immigrants did a reverse journey on a promotional tour sponsored by U.S. financial interests to spread “America fever” and this prompted more departures.

Subsequently, the first major wave occurred from 1866 to 1873 (111,000) when income inequality in Norway reached unusually high levels. This was followed by several years of depression, agricultural disasters causing famines, mounting debts and forcing people to sell themselves into indentured servitude just to survive. Intrepid voyagers like Elizabeth joined the second surge from 1879-1893 (250,000), that averaged more than 18,000 annually, such that only Ireland had a higher rate of emigration.

A third and final wave from 1900 to 1910 saw more than 200,000 departures, in part due to a substantial population increase. Altogether, nearly one million people emigrated to North America during the second half of the century. Whatever else might be said about them later it’s indisputable that this was an emigration of severely oppressed people whose lives had become unbearable. They faced two choices: emigrate or starve.

For a visual, albeit fictional sense of this period, I recommend two internationally-acclaimed films, “The Emigrants” (1971) and the sequel, “The New Land” (1972), that graphically convey the travails of, in this case, Swedish emigrants in a manner that closely mirrors that of my Norwegian ancestors. Directed by Jan Troell and starring Liv Ullman and Max von Sydow, they are based on Vilhelm Moberg’s novel, *The Emigrants*. During the film’s production, Troell made extensive use of locations in Minnesota.⁴

My take is that my ancestors were pushed and pulled by forces over which they had little to no control over forces which sociologist Karen Hanson contends, “dislocated peasants and dispossessed Native peoples.”⁵ Hanson doesn’t go into specifics about these “missing pieces” but prefiguring later discussion and as one other astute observer explains, upon arriving in North America, the ends were unchanging. That is, the intentions of those responsible for colonialism was “to shore up access to Indigenous people’s property for the purpose of state formation, settlement, and capitalist development.”⁶

The genesis of these global forces originated far in advance of England’s rise which eventually London’s invasion of North America, settler colonialism, slavery, white supremacy and 1776. The continuity continues apace today with the U.S. capitalist global empire.⁷ As such, I’ve tried to be mindful of Frank Joyce’s wise counsel that “Knowing how the system was created is essential to working out how to take it apart and reconstruct it.”⁸

In what follows I attempt to revisit and unpack the reasons for my previous externally manufactured ignorance and vast storehouse of misinformation about the reasons for my ancestor’s arrival here and in dispossessing the indigenous people. My conceit is to insert instances of personal memoir in hopes they will help explicate

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the subject. I discuss the capitalist logic of dispossession, invasion, elimination, role of settlers, the “whiteness” factor, mascots, state policies of brainwashing Indigenous children through boarding schools, cultural misappropriation, assimilation, revisionist history and the future.

What lessons might we learn from deconstructing this history and begin doing what Kenyan novelist and postcolonial scholar Ngugi wa Thiong’o describes as “decolonizing the mind.” He used it to explain how colonized people needed to liberate themselves from an insidious, brainwashing colonial mentality that all things “Western” were superior to being indigenous.⁹ Here I’m repurposing that here to suggest that descendants of a colonial state also need to liberate our minds no matter where that leads. It’s an awkward, uncomfortable, and oftentimes gut-wrenching undertaking but we need to critically reconsider what we’ve internalized about U.S. history. We need to reconstruct it because substantial portions were lies. Absent that deprogramming, the most propitious path for moving forward will remain elusive.

Finally, in initiating this exploration, my intent was not to shame, blame, exculpate or pronounce absolution on settlers but to find at least a close approximation of the truth. Further, I readily acknowledge that over time my ancestors assumed a white identity with all its attendant benefits, many of which adhered to their descendants, including, of course, myself.

My Grandparents Obtain Land

My grandfather, Tobias Aanonson, also of peasant stock, was not the eldest son in the family therefore not in line to inherit any property. His prospects in Norway were nil and he left Norway for Minnesota during that same period and began toiling as a lumberjack in the state’s North Woods.

Prior to marrying Tobias, my grandmother Emma had been sold into indentured servitude by her indigent mother to a wealthy family owning a boarding house in northern Minnesota who paid for her steerage tickets. There, she labored under harsh and restrictive rules and it was common for young girls to perform this work under 5-7-year contracts but in many cases the servitude for a child would last until maturity. Conceivably, the term for my grandmother continued until she reached 17 and married my grandfather who was 15 years her senior. Family anecdotes have it that her experience as a boarding house servant was embittering and exacted an emotional toll for the remainder of her life. One result was bitterness toward her mother

and another was that despised indoor work like cooking and cleaning. These were left to the five daughters as Emma labored outdoors alongside Tobias. I suspect that variations on this story could be recounted by many others.

My grandparents began farming in southern Minnesota in 1892. Given that the best land was already claimed, documents show that they purchased their plot from someone who had almost certainly received it “free” under The Homestead Act of 1862, signed by President Abraham Lincoln. In a speech in February, 1861, Lincoln had told the nation that “wild lands of the country should be distributed so that every man should have the means and opportunity of benefiting his condition.” Indigenous people did not fit this category.

With their passage, the Homestead Acts became, “unquestionably the most extensive, radical redistribute government policy in US history” as they granted 246 million acres to 1.6 million individuals, some ten percent of the land in the United States.¹⁰ In terms of Norwegian-Americans, it’s impossible to overstate the importance of the Homestead Act because “Individuals without property to earn a living in their home country now had an opportunity to become landed.”¹¹ Claimants had only to be U.S. citizens, intend to become one, file an application, pay a fee of \$18, improve the land while remaining on it for five years and file a deed of ownership.

In 1863, some 20,000 claims were immediately filed in Minnesota and the total acreage was the largest allotment for any state in the nation. Less well known is the fact that all the elements needed to actually start a farm were expensive, roughly \$795 (or \$17,500 in 2003 dollars) and thus beyond the reach of many and we learn from the National Archives, that through massive fraud, “Most of the land went to speculators, cattlemen, miners, lumbermen and railroads.”¹²

Betty Bergland, professor emerita of history at the University of Wisconsin/River Falls, makes the important, clarifying observation about the Homestead Act that it was primarily the federal policies of war, removal, exile and reservations that enabled Norwegian immigrants to “claim land, gain citizenship and opportunities to pass that along to succeeding generations.”¹³ Again, as will be addressed later, the motives behind these policies require further explication.

The “pull” of the land was also furthered by the Federal government’s after-the-fact legalization of “squatting” on unsurveyed land, boosterism from land agents, government officials, and town promoters, ads appearing in local newspapers and letters from immigrants themselves sent back to Norway. In the 1890s and early 1900s, my mother and her seven siblings were born and raised on one of these parcels of land near Belgrade, Minnesota.

I should state that my Norwegian immigrant ancestors are neither abstract “settler colonialists” to me nor tinged with its pejorative connotation. Perhaps part of my inability to conjure up that image stems from fond memories of summer visits to my grandparent’s farm in Minnesota with its plain, wood frame farmhouse, heated only with a wood-burning stove in the kitchen. Across the farmyard, I recall outbuildings that included a sagging, red painted barn with a hay loft and empty stalls. A ramshackle poultry house with cobweb laced broken windows but still containing some scattered chicken feathers, an aging tractor, two-hole outhouse and a rusty water pump

that required priming. (Note: My mother told me that rope was strung between the house and the barn for safe passage for doing chores during whiteout winter blizzards.)

One experience indelibly imprinted on my mind occurred when I was about seven or eight years old. My Grandpa Tobias let me be his “hired hand” for the day and we started in the wheat field. My assignment was to gather and stack several bundles of wheat together to form a shock. After a long morning in the field I’d only managed to assemble one vague facsimile and it was falling apart due to my inept application of baling twine. On our conversational-less walk back to the house for lunch, my Grandpa uttered a few words in Norwegian and pressed a silver fifty cent coin into my palm. The coin disappeared soon thereafter but a few years ago, I purchased three of them, all dated 1951, to pass along to my grandchildren one day along with a story about their great, great, grand-father. (Note: When the farm was sold after my grandparent’s death, no proceeds were passed along to my mother and her siblings and instead went to pay taxes.)

Settler’s Preconceptions?

Some evidence suggests that the newcomers believed a vast virgin wilderness was waiting to be settled, a “land without people for people without land,” the founding deception so effectively employed by Zionists to lure unsuspecting Diaspora Jews to Palestine. Another interpretation is that settlers were under the impression that the Natives had moved on long before the settlers arrived.

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As will be explored in some detail later, we know that in the 1860s, Norwegian journalists helped spur a sizable influx of Norwegians to North Dakota and Minnesota. For just one example, aware of the major economic collapse in Norway and its desperate land-poor peasants, Paul Hjelm-Hansen, a journalist employed by the governor of Minnesota, portrayed the region as an agricultural oasis “with places for many thousand farmers.”¹⁴ Minnesota and North Dakota were magical landscapes where “one only had to arrive, put plow in the ground, and throw seeds into the rich black earth.”¹⁵ Hjelm-Hansen’s articles appeared in several Norwegian newspapers in 1869 and had the desired effect.

Whatever their preconceptions might have been, one authoritative source explains that as immigrants surged into the Minnesota territory they found that the land was “already settled by Native Americans.” Due to a devious, semantic sleight-of-hand this was taken to mean “the right of occupancy, not the right of ownership.”¹⁶ According to Swedish scholar Gunlog Fur

“The fiction of empty land available for cultivation required an active denial of an Indian presence, even when they were everywhere... It also served to deny the integral role of violence in the expansion of white settlement across the North American continent.”¹⁷

Two brief scenes, highlighting a few fairy tale assumptions are found in the aforementioned film, “The Emigrants.” In the first one, two boys are excitedly reading a promotional booklet about the promising New World and one exclaims “Even slaves have a higher standard of living than most European peasants. I want to sign up to be a slave!” In the second, some Scandinavian immigrants are on a paddle boat heading across the Great Lakes toward Minnesota, when one expresses amazement at seeing wealthy, first-class passengers strolling on the upper deck. A fellow passenger patiently explains that the U.S. is not at all like the class society they fled because in America “These people who have been here long enough are already rich. We’re still poor because we just got here. It takes a little time.”

The historical record reveals soon enough that many of these naive settlers began experiencing the “promised land” as a cruel lie when the power of capital emerged with the likes of robber barons Cornelius Vanderbilt, J.D. Rockefeller, Jay Gould, and J.P. Morgan. In short order, a substantial number of farmers lost their land as the very wealthy, white 1% claimed ownership of over half the property in the country and one fourth of the nation’s wealth. By 1900, that grew to 10 percent owning 90 percent of the country’s wealth.

In response, class conflict began with a railroad strike on July 16, 1977 and the consequent Great Upheaval of workers was met with massive state violence against strikers, workers and protesters over the next three decades.¹⁸ Historian Mary Neth captures what this meant for family farmers: “In rural America, the development of industrial capitalism directed collided with a family-based labor system” and many people were displaced, “...including farmers on small farms, tenants, hired workers, and unpaid women and youths.”¹⁹

Foreshadowing a position amplified later in this essay, I’m suggesting that the immigrants had performed their indispensable function for the capitalist colonial state in settling expropriated land, increasing population numbers and legitimizing the property state. It only remained for elites and their enablers to retain settler allegiance via myriad forms of scapegoating, repression, and propaganda, especially a stepped-up emphasis on “whiteness.” Concurrently, if not literally eradicating all the remaining Indigenes, they began devising methods to commence cultural genocide.

Beneficiaries of Government Policy

By the year 2000, the number of adult descendants of the original Homestead Act recipients numbered at least 46 million people or a quarter of the US adult population, virtually all of them white.²⁰ Only 5000 African-Americans benefited from the 1862 Act. It’s beyond disputation that these government programs and policies funneled myriad opportunities to white people at the expense of others. As one student of the subject points out, “For the wealthy, inheritance provides a genealogical distance from conquest, genocide, and colonial slavery that offers a cover of ostensible innocence and launders accumulated incomes.”²¹ Confining ourselves

solely to approximate economic calculations and excluding cultural capital which is immensely important but harder to determine, land acquisition itself translated to several trillion dollars.

This bookends the dollar value that white Americans profited from unpaid Black slave labor with those estimates starting at \$1 trillion dollars, a sum attaching graphic numbers to “white privilege.” By contrast, there are three million descendants of the native peoples who once inhabited this land and we know that indigenous people as a whole have the highest poverty rate among all minority groups in the United States.

In the South, there were some four million emancipated African-Americans in 1865 and the Southern Homestead Act (SHA) was passed on June 21, 1866. The Act opened some 46 million acres of public land—much of it unsuitable for farming because of swamps and forests—in Alabama, Arkansas, Florida, Louisiana and Mississippi. African Americans were given priority until January 1, 1867. However, several insurmountable obstacles blocked recently freed slaves from benefiting from it. The most egregious barrier was that at the end of the war, former slaves had been tricked, cajoled or forced into signing labor contracts, often to work on former plantation land as sharecroppers where they also accrued steep debts.

Breaking a contract resulted in onerous consequences, including the chain gang. As historian Keri Leighton makes clear, Blacks were “locked into these contracts until the very day when they would stop receiving special homestead benefits” As a result, by 1869, only 4,000 African Americans succeeded in staking a claim under the SHA and only 1,000 property deeds were issued. Again, most of the recipients were white.²² The law was repealed in 1876. If it’s not been done, a research project on the fate of the original recipients and their descendants would be valuable. My hypothesis is that because of state sanctioned oppression and myriad forms of informal white supremacy, any positive gains were stillborn.

The Black experience centered on enslaving, breeding and violent control in pursuit of cheap labor. Their bodies were commodities.

The Logic of Indigenous Removal

In terms of Indigenous removal, the picture will remain opaque if we don’t grasp that the logic of dispossession was not premised on race but on where Indigenous people lived. In Deborah Bird Rose’s pithy observation, “To get in the way of settler colonialism, all the victim had to do was stay at home.”²³ The Australian anthropologist and ethnographer Patrick Wolfe, famously argued that “It is ‘territoriality’ that remains the colonialist’s irreducible element, not race, or religion, ethnicity, grade of civilization, etc.”²⁴

This operates through a “protracted invasion” and the logic of elimination” that necessitates the destruction of indigenous people—but not necessarily genocide, as land is the objective. Eventually, this even allows for granting limited individual

rights and cultural protections as these help rationalize expropriation, tie the indigenous remnant to the state and help to convince white people that they are superior and the more deserving occupants of the land.

The methods for violently oppressing Indians and Blacks were different. On the one hand, as noted, the colonialist state's policies of extermination and forcible relocation of Indigenes was for the singular purpose of seizing land. To reiterate, in political scientist's Walter Hixson's concise wording, this was a "winner takes all" proposition. On the other, the Black experience centered on enslaving, breeding and violent control in pursuit of cheap labor. Their bodies were commodities. Both cases involved massive state terrorism, rooted in the categorical capitalist imperative of "Expand or Perish"—by any means necessary. It's in this specific economic context that we have the artificial social construction of white supremacy and race.

After the Civil War, for Blacks it was Jim Crow and the Ku Klux Klan, exclusion from key provisions of the New Deal, formal and informal segregation, COINTELPRO, the prison-military complex, Nixon's "Southern Strategy" a racially biased "drug war" leading to the incarceration state, revival of Jim Crow stereotyping, "super-predators," decimation of black wealth, racist police violence, and the complicity of the black mis-leadership class. For Indians, after 1890, it was more broken treaties, continued dispossession, slaughter, exile, the reservation, writing Indians out of history, cultural appropriation, commodification and forcible assimilation. The latter means that 80 percent of Native Americans reside off the reservation, primarily in large urban areas.

Assimilation as a Disingenuous Euphemism

Assimilation deserves special attention in that nothing approaches its magnitude and unspeakable cruelty more than the cultural genocide practiced by Indian Boarding Schools. Their purpose, in the pithy words of Gen. Richard Henry Pratt, who founded the Carlisle Indian School in Pennsylvania, was "To Kill the Indian in him, and save the man." Over the years, hundreds of thousands of children were taken from their families and communities, beginning with the Civilization Act of 1819 which sought to introduce children as early as six years old to "the habits and arts of civilization." Uncle Sam paid bounties to those capturing runaways from the schools. Later, under the Indian Appropriation Act of 1851 and the Peace Act of 1869, these schools went off-reservation and parents were not even allowed to visit their children because it might retard the pace of the civilizing process. The children were schooled in the importance of private property, material wealth and Christianity. David Wallace Adams was not engaging in hyperbole when he titled his book on Indian Boarding Schools, "Educating for Extinction."

By 1926, more than 60% children or 83 percent of Indian school-age children were attending these boarding schools. Coincidentally, in 1924, the government had imposed full citizenship on Native Americans, also meant to foster assimilation in the form of nationalism, patriotism, and accepting the "American Way of Life"—while further distancing themselves from their tribal identity, culture and language. As for the boarding schools, it's almost unfathomable to realize that parents did not gain the

legal right to deny their child being forced to attend one of these schools until 1978 with passage of the Indian Child Welfare Act.

Indigenous Dispossession

It's not generally known that for much of the West, homesteading was not the primary means of dispossession. It may sound like a difference without distinction but the 1830 Indian Removal Act used the U.S. Army to force several tribes to relocate west of the Mississippi River in order to accommodate white settlers. In Nebraska, the federal government had already seized some 30 million acres from Nebraska tribes before 1862. Further, in many places, white vigilantes and local "militias" acted on their own in tracking down and murdering Natives with the government a convenient few steps behind.

In Minnesota, some indigenous land was taken by the Treaty of Traverse des Sioux, signed on July 23, 1851 under which the Sioux were forced to cede 24,000,000 acres of their territory and "relocated" to temporary reservations along the Minnesota River. Payments for the land proved to be far less than promised and then were halted altogether. Nevertheless, in the Dakotas and Minnesota, after 1862, homesteading played the major role in dispossession.

In 1862, the Dakota Sioux, in retaliation for years of mistreatment by whites and facing imminent starvation, embarked on an implacable, fierce, but ultimately futile attempt to drive out the colonial invaders. They were crushed by the U.S. Army in the Dakota War of 1862 and this culminated on December 26, 1862 with the largest mass execution in American history. After a hastily convened military commission and totally unfair trial, 303 Dakota were sentenced to death and on signed orders from President Abraham Lincoln, thirty-eight of them were hanged from a giant scaffold in the center of Mankato, Minnesota (another town in which I lived) an event attended by 4,000 spectators. Just as the trap door began to open, each one called out his or her name in native tongue and declared "I'm here. I'm here." (Note: Confederate generals killed over 400,000 union soldiers. Lincoln never ordered the execution of a single one.)

After the hanging, the remaining Dakota were evicted from their ancestral homeland to prison camps in Iowa, others were forced to march barefoot in the snow to Crow Creek, SD. Many died in prison or in a concentration camp in Sisseton, SD while still others escaped to Canada. A bounty was placed on the scalps of every Dakota man, woman and child. The hangings followed six weeks of fighting between Native Americans and the U.S. Army that had signaled the advent of three decades of fighting between Native Americans and the U.S. government across the Great Plains. Several accounts agree that many Norwegian-Americans began voicing increased antipathy toward indigenes after 1862.

In 1877, the Dawes Act was enacted and led to catastrophic consequences for Indigenous people. Named after Sen. Henry Dawes of Massachusetts, Dawes left the Sioux Nation broken into isolated, fragmented small reservations surrounded by immigrants. Each Indian head of household was given a plot while the remaining substantial tribal land was declared "surplus" and made available to white homesteaders. Under the Dawes Act and the "Dead Indian Act of 1902, 100 million more

acres were lost, some 65 percent of reservation land. By 1920, all the prime land had been taken over by non-Indian ranchers.

In February, 1890, the federal government broke a treaty with the Great Sioux Nation and divided the reservation in North Dakota into five smaller ones. The primary reason was to make more land available for settlers but it was meant “to break up tribal relationships” and “conform Indians to the white man’s ways, peaceably if they will, or forcibly if they must.”²⁵

On December 29 of the same year at Wounded Knee Ridge in South Dakota, the U.S. Army surrounded a Lakota Sioux encampment at Wounded Knee Ridge in South Dakota. After setting up Hotchkiss guns that fired one shot per second, the troops proceeded to mow down some 300 unarmed old men, women and children. After this bloody massacre, the government awarded Congressional Medals of Honor to 20 of the soldiers for demonstrating “conspicuous and intrepid bravery.”

Skirmishes punctuated the next several years but Wounded Knee demarcated the “closing of the frontier.” After this final military defeat of the Indigenes, white identity and a host of other factors merged to rationalize dispossession. However, I will tip my hand and suggest examining these factors should not divert and obscure our attention from the fact that the United States was founded as a capitalist state colonial entity. The state and its enablers were the legitimating authority for genocide and whereas “Whiteness” assumed a critical instrumental role, it was not the determining one. As I will argue later, class retains primacy over other important, coterminous but ultimately among auxiliary factors in our search for an ultimate causal explanation.

Today, two of the five poorest communities in the United States—Allen #1 and Wounded Knee #5—are located in Oglala Lakota County which is totally contained within South Dakota’s Pine Ridge Reservation. The county also has the lowest life expectancy, highest unemployment, and at \$8,768, is the poorest in the United States.

The “Fighting Sioux” Mascot

Although I also lived in Minnesota and South Dakota, my formative years were spent in Fargo, North Dakota along the Red River of the North on the eastern border of the state. The city was named for William Fargo, an owner of the Wells-Fargo Express Company and one the directors of the Union Pacific Railroad whose tracks ran through the center of town and held up traffic three times a day. When UP engineers and surveyors first arrived, they were accompanied by U.S. Army officers. This continuing symbiotic partnership between the capitalist state and big business was exemplified by Congress granting rail companies 10 million acres of free public land in Minnesota, amounting to 20 percent of the state’s land area. It was, of course, in the interest of railroad officials to lure immigrants to the region because it increased the value of their line. The construction of Fort Abercrombie in 1857, just thirty miles south of Fargo and the first fort in North Dakota, helped prompt immigrants to surge into the region through the “Gateway to the West” and stake their claims. Fort Abercrombie was followed by six more military bases across the state in the 1860s and early 1870s.

This Native American cultural appropriation was perfectly normal to me and reinforced stereotyping while simultaneously having a damaging effect on Native Americans’ sense of self-worth, self-confidence and self-image.

A program closely related to the aforementioned Dawes legislation was The Morrill Land Grant Act of 1862 and expanded in 1890, which gave the proceeds of the sale of federal land expropriated from indigenous tribes to state governments to set up land grant colleges and universities. Our house in Fargo was not far from North Dakota State University (NDSU), a college established under The Morrill Land Grant Act. As with so much else, I was totally ignorant of this history and if I thought about it all, I probably felt Morrill was actually something that the government got right.

NDSU’s athletic teams are called “The Bison” or “The Thundering Herd” and their traditional in-state rival is the University of North Dakota (UND), “The Fighting Sioux.” After a seven-year legal battle with the NCAA and a state-wide vote, in 2015, UND’s name was officially changed to the “Fighting Hawks” in 2015. Opponents of the change said the logo showed “pride and tradition” but the 21 Native American-related organizations argued that it disrespected their culture and the strongest advocates for the name change were members of the Standing Rock Tribe.

Even in 2021, the Fighting Sioux logo remains on seats in the hockey arena, on a huge statue of Sioux Chief Sitting Bull sitting astride a horse outside the arena, and many fans still wear clothing adorned with the vintage logo to games. This Native American cultural appropriation was perfectly normal to me and reinforced stereotyping while simultaneously having a damaging effect on Native Americans’ sense of self-worth, self-confidence and self-image.

In the words of Paul Chat Smith, a curator at the National Museum of the American Indian, “Multiple studies have shown that these mascots, which are stereotypes of Native peoples, cause real damage.” The American Psychological Society concurs and in 2005, after citing voluminous research on self-esteem and social identity development, called for “the immediate retirement of all-American Indian mascots, symbols, images and personalities by high schools, colleges, universities, athletic teams and organizations” A.P.A. President Ronald Levant added these negative lessons “are sending the wrong message to all students.”²⁶

Emblematic of its continuing currency is the fifteen-year controversy that was only resolved this year in nearby Radnor, Pennsylvania. The issue that divided this affluent community and its highly rated high school (#4 in the state) was the high school’s mascot: An American Indian warrior known as the Radnor “Red Raider” Starting in 2016 and again in 2018, the school newspaper began condemning the “Tomahawk Chop” performed at athletic contests and advocated rethinking the mas-

cot. After several contentious public meetings and vehement opposition from older alumni, a list of names, minus Red Raiders, was whittled down to four, and students chose the name “Raptors.” In 2020, some 2,000 schools and institutions continue to retain these mascots. In my home state of Pennsylvania, 64 high schools still retain Native American mascots and names.

Indian Head Penny for Your Thoughts?

A personal example that might seem innocuous on first glance and not fit the mascot designation, is the Indian Head Penny. Having Native-Americans on my mind in recent months, I recalled that in my youth I’d been given a small collection (10-12) of these Indian-themed coins from my mother who’d probably received them from her parents.

The coins were produced by the United States Bureau of the Mint from 1859 to 1909 when they were replaced by the Lincoln penny. James Longacre, Chief Engraver of the Philadelphia Mint, designed the coin and used the facial image of his daughter Sarah to depict “Lady Liberty,” an Indian princess adorned in a traditional Indian headdress. Longacre found nothing morally objectionable or inconsistent about the image and certainly not “repulsive to be associated with Liberty.” He said the implicit message was that “We were never in bondage to anyone.”

The Mint’s director loved the depiction and wrote that the new “Indian Head would present an ideal of America—the sweeping plumes of the North American Indian giving it the character of North America.” There was some initial grousing about the image of a “savage” Indian on the face of America’s legal tender but using “a sanitized Caucasian girl with Greek features to represent an Indian made it okay.” She was in fact a “Good Indian,” the direct opposite of those marauding ones who were resisting the gifts of civilization proffered by the colonialist state.²⁷ The fact that the coin was being praised and circulated during the period when the mass slaughter of Indians was in overdrive qualifies the statements as an early example of chutzpah.

Lest one think this is now discredited thinking, in surveying sites that buy and seek rare coins in 2021, I found the consensus view remains that the “The Indian Head Penny embodies the bold, independent, timeless spirit as much today as when was first minted in 1859.” Not only does it reflect “Native Americans’ unique role in shaping U.S. history,” it’s motif “honors the United States’ Native American heritage” and “When it comes to American coins it is hard to get more American than Lady Liberty and Native Americans.”

In writing about the motives behind employing such images, Yale historian Alan Trachtenberg concludes they was about the fact that “Indians had been slaughtered for the sake of the new race of Americans; they must be resurrected and commemorated, their ‘pure’ image pressed in gold”—or in this case, copper.²⁸ The coin sanctified manifest destiny and conveyed the message that Indians were done an enormous favor for which they were ungrateful. Finally, to return to my earlier point, the Indian Head Penny was “an early version of an Indian mascot,” some of which could be found over a century later in valuable rare coin collections. It’s another image lodged in America’s delusional, collective, colonized mind.

Another egregious example to which I was oblivious was that the two states admitted to the union on November 2, 1889, were North and South “Dakota,” appropriating the name the Sioux nation called itself and meaning “friends or allies.” Today, about half the names of American states are Indian in origin, a not subtle assumption of ownership whereby “white dominant society assumes control of the meaning of Nateness.” It justifies the “maintenance of a system of domination and control—whether intentionally or unintentionally—where white supremacy is safeguarded.”²⁹ In short, this was and remains a crude attempt to sever Native people from their cultural heritage as they are subsumed by white supremacy and are continually reconquered by other means.

Finally, there’s a long history of cultural misappropriation on behalf of commercial projects and one egregious example is the travel industry. From 1933 to 1950 there were “Wigwam Motels,” mostly in the Southwest, the Wooden Indian Bar in New York City’s Americana Hotel only closed in 1992 after protests and in 2017, Airbnb issued an apology for an ad promising a “true Sioux” experience in Joshua Tree California even though no members of the tribe ever resided there. Squaw Valley, site of the 1960 Winter Olympics, is changing its name after complaints from Native Americans that the name is a racist and sexist slur. Just this year, an Arizona businessman proposed building a massive glamping resort on the outskirts of Flagstaff. Called “2 Guns,” it would have all the usual amenities but also feature 70 tepees, 12 hogans and incongruously, 43 Conestoga wagons. The premise was that “authenticity” would lure well-heeled tourists.³⁰

My Episodic Encounters With “Indians”

In terms of my personal experience, I had few direct contacts with Indians—or were they simply unseen? That five percent of the state’s population was scattered on five reservations and North Dakota remains the only state with a majority of Indians living on reservations. I recall a few Indians hanging out on one seedy downtown street in Fargo where they would sometimes purchase liquor for under-age guys and be repaid with a bottle of ultra-cheap Thunderbird, what we called “bum wine” and associated it with Indians.

Here, one anecdote that merits retelling concerns Fort Yates in North Dakota. It was constructed to keep the Indians in line and after Col. George Custer’s “tragedy” at the Battle of Little Big Horn” on June 25, 1876, the number of troops stationed at the Fort peaked at 3,000 and 65 buildings. The fort was named to honor Captain George Yates who died in the battle. Also, after Sitting Bull was killed on December 14, 1890, he was buried at Fort Yates and earlier, white missionary assimilationist nuns had started an Indian boarding school there in 1877. I mention this background because like so much else, I was totally ignorant of this history and only several decades later did I began to recognize more examples of constructed Indian-ness, really, manufactured ignorance, for the racism they embodied.

In 1961, as a high school, cross-country runner, I competed in the state XC championships against the storied runners from Fort Yates, the perennial favorite to win the title. A town some 60 miles from Bismarck, Fort Yates had a population of 1100 at the time which has now dwindled to less than 200. Before the race, my coach

cautioned me that my major competition for individual honors was an Indian from Fort Yates. Curious, a few minutes before approaching the starting line, I asked a member of his team to point him out. His teammate replied with a laugh, “Oh, he was too hungover this morning and missed the team bus.” I mention this because that conversation undoubtedly reinforced the idea in my mind—one common at the time—that Indians were weak, unreliable and naturally predisposed toward alcoholism. I had internalized the dominant society problematizing of Indigenous youth that contributed to stereotyping of Natives as inferior to whites. I went on to win the race but is it totally implausible to speculate that the outcome was a symptom of the colonial condition?

Whether or not it was applicable in that particular case, I was totally oblivious to the historical context which is summed up by two authoritative researchers on alcohol use in Indian country: “What is not recognized is that alcohol use and even suicide may be functional behavior adaptations within a hostile and hopeless social context.” In other words, we need to know more about alcohol abuse and historical trauma. Eduardo Duran and Bonnie Duran go on to advocate a need for a “postcolonial history of alcohol.”³¹

Parenthetically, the following year I raised funds at my Minnesota college for SNCC, the Student Nonviolent Coordinating Committee’s civil rights activism in the South and even hitch-hiked to Louisiana in an attempt to get involved. At no point did I connect those actions with the historical and ongoing oppression of Native Americans in my own backyard. Growing up on the Great Plains, I knew nothing about this actual history and like my peers was subjected to disingenuous, sanitized, elite-serving origin stories.

There’s Gold in Them Thar Hills!

A microcosm that serves to encapsulate several points in this essay and is illustrative of the woeful state of my political awareness at the time is Mount Rushmore. Carved into the granite slope over the Black Hills of South Dakota. Mount Rushmore was a popular and almost obligatory destination for family car trips. Until only a few years ago, I was unaware that this “Shrine of Democracy,” this revered site of Americana, was known to the Lakota as Six Grandfathers Mountain. Its location

What if instead of presented with a totally fabricated history, a visit to Mount Rushmore could have been a lesson in critical thinking, a teaching moment?

was considered not only sacred religious ground but the apex of the universe for the Lakota people. After signing the 1868 Treaty of Laramie with the U.S. government, the Lakota obtained exclusive use of the Black Hills. Ten years later, when gold was discovered and thousands of miners rushed to the area, the government rescinded the

treaty. On February 28, 1877, the federal government officially stole the land for the second time and began profiting from the gold, minerals and timber.

The following essential background, which like so much else, is egregiously ignored by historians and missing from the classroom, is as follows: In 1874, President Ulysses S. Grant ordered Lt. Col. George Armstrong Custer to take his troops in the Black Hills and his official mission was to find the optimum site for a military post. Left out of the narrative is that Grant paid out of his own pocket for two prospectors to accompany Custer to follow up on rumors that the Black Hills was rich in gold. The first dispatch from a journalist on the expedition confirmed the rumors when he wrote “From the grass roots down it was ‘pay dirt.’” A “New El Dorado” had been discovered and Grant began scheming about how to renege on his earlier, solemn “Peace Policy” pledge toward the Indians.

Documents unearthed by diligent researchers at the Smithsonian reveal that in a closed meeting, Grant said, “The Lakotas must go or get whipped” which was a subterfuge to begin manufacturing complaints against the indigenous population. In the meantime, believing they would refuse to leave, a secret plan was hatched to launch a campaign against unsuspecting Indian villages. And in response to his insistent instigation, Grant’s Indian agents in the West sent back totally fabricated stories about the Indians not only being defiant and “hostile” but recommending that a thousand soldiers be dispatched to the Black Hills “to throw the ‘untamable’ Lakotas into subjugation. One unanticipated consequence was the Little Big Horn debacle but after the Indians had been subdued, Secretary of War J. Donald Cameron assured Congress and the nation that “the accidental discovery of gold” did not cause U.S. military operations in the Black Hills. On October 4, 1927, the sculptor Gutzon Borglum took on the Mount Rushmore carving project, in his words, as “a testament to American exceptionalism” and “a space for uncomplicated patriotism.”³² Looking back, what if instead of presented with a totally fabricated history, a visit to Mount Rushmore could have been a lesson in critical thinking, a teaching moment?

Formal Miseducation

A closely related adjunct to the above, is that undergraduates at my Minnesota college were in a potentially privileged position to learn about the truth about these matters, and especially immigrants’ settlements and in our own Red River Valley, from a nationally acknowledged expert on the topic. A local farmer himself, Hiram Drache was a professor in the History Department, author of a dozen books and invited speaker for hundreds of talks around the country. Even after this long passage of time, I hoped I would recall at least one class lecture on the near annihilation of Native-Americans but none come to mind.

To check my unreliable memory, I went back and looked at Drache’s books and found only a few scant references to Indians including “Indian problems,” a single mention of the terrifying “Sioux outbreak” of 1862 and a military garrison being constructed “to watch the southern Minnesota Indians.” In what was arguably his well-known book (now in 12 printings) from 1964, the five stages of settlement, from rugged frontiersman to the frontier’s end with the arrival of urbanization I was

unable to detect even a hint at the violent methods by which all the free, fertile land had been obtained.³³

In an effort to see if he'd made amends for his earlier professorial sins of omission, I looked over his 343-page book from 1992, titled *Taming of the Wilderness*, the focus of which was on the northern half of Minnesota. It was praised for its enlightened treatment of this "huge empty space" I was not surprised by the meticulous research and attention to the smallest detail. However, the only reference to Native Americans was about the Minnesota State Supreme Court ruling that Indians living on Federal property could not vote in a referendum on changes in the liquor laws.³⁴

We might also have learned from a bona fide expert that at the higher levels of officialdom, Territorial Governor, Alexander Ramsey's wasn't an outlier when he wrote to President Lincoln in 1862 and placed all the blame on the "savage" Indians: "This is not our war, it is a native war... More than five hundred whites have been murdered by the Indians." Another individual who was emblematic of elite opinion and the rhetoric of extinction was the aforementioned Henry Hastings Sibley from the Dakota War of 1862.

I recall Sibley's name being memorialized by counties, parks, streets and schools across the state including my traveling on the Sibley Memorial Highway near the Twin Cities. As with so much else about local history, I was totally ignorant of the fact that Sibley, Minnesota's first Governor, was also Ethnic Cleanser-in-Chief on land that he'd once characterized as "pristine." Col. Sibley commanded 1,200 troops U.S. troops during his "punitive expeditions" and in 1862, he wrote the following to Alexander Ramsey about Indians: "My heart is steeled against them, and if I have the means, and can catch them, I will sweep them with the besom of death."

Fittingly, after being mustered out of the military, Sibley served as president of the Minnesota Chamber of Commerce, on the boards of railroads, banks and was a regent of the University of Minnesota. Princeton University bestowed an honorary doctorate on Sibley in 1888. It's encouraging that, in 2020, under pressure from Native Americans and citizens who'd previously known only a sanitized version of his past, Sibley's name was erased from a high school in the Twin Cities and changed to Two Rivers High School. A quarter of the current students and many previous graduates signed a petition supporting the name change.

On a related note, after years of fierce wrangling and court reversals, the name Lake Calhoun in Minneapolis was restored to its original Lakota name, Bde Maka Ska. It had been named to honor U.S. Secretary of War John C. Calhoun, prominent slave owner and author of the Indian Removal Act. In a split decision in 2021, the Minnesota Supreme Court ruled in favor of the change and shortly thereafter, shopping centers, public squares, entire neighborhoods, cycle shops, and gyms quickly shed the name "Calhoun." The speed of change was undoubtedly expedited by the new awareness following George Floyd's killing in Minneapolis and the Black Lives Matter movement.

A final example, although not specifically about Minnesota and the Dakotas, concerns my miseducation about Lt. Col. Kit Carson, the iconic frontier hero of the Old West. As a child I had a Kit Carson cap pistol, wanted to be Carson when playing Cowboys and Indians and in the early 1950s I faithfully watched "The Adventures

of Kit Carson" every day after school. Undoubtedly, this was also true for kids in Colorado where I later did my graduate work from 1968-1973 and became familiar with the 14,000-foot Mount Kit Carson, one of the "Elevens" revered by climbers in the state.

Yet, even though then in my mid 20s, I confess to being unaware of the fact that Carson was a war criminal who spearheaded the U.S. government's genocidal campaign against the Navahos. In 1862-63, after some "Indian trouble"—translated: they refused to accept confinement on a reservation—Col. Carson led a brutal campaign against the Navahos, burning their crops, destroying their villages, and slaughtering their livestock. He then proceeded to round up 8,000 Navajo men, women and children and forced them on what became known as the "Long Walk" of 300 miles from Arizona to the Bosque Redondo Reservation in New Mexico, a trek taking over two months. In 2011, by a 10-0 vote, a federal agency denied a request to rename the mountain. However, an encouraging development occurred last year when the Kit Carson elementary school in Las Vegas changed its name.

The annual Kit Carson Mountain Men Rendezvous goes on in Kit Carson, Colorado where participants are strongly encouraged to wear "primitive" clothing as they participate in gun-shooting centered festivities. And if one is in California, they can relax at the "rustically elegant" Kit Carson Lodge in the Sierra Nevada mountains, a resort that dates back 95 years. Yet another available option for "pioneer fun" and an authentic legend of the Old West experience is the five-day Kit Carson Wagon Train re-enactment. Finally, on the educational site "Kids-n-Cowboys" we learn that Kit Carson helped make "the great American expansion possible."

Socialists Among the Settlers?

At this point, I admit that before starting this undertaking I assumed I'd come across a few heroes, some radical dissenters who at least raised the matter of indigenous dispossession even as they gained from it? We know that by 1920, some 50,000 immigrants returned to Norway. Many had sent money orders to the old country for the eventual purchase of land. It's not inconceivable that some of them also returned out of disgust with what they learned on the American frontier but, in general, the record is silent. In terms of those who remained, two of the most instructive, albeit troubling cases I came across were Marcus Thrane, a radical Midwest socialist and GAA PAAS (Press Forward), the leading Norwegian-language socialist newspaper of the time.

Marcus Thrane admired the Paris Commune, organized the first rural workers' union in Norway with some 30,000 members, edited its newspaper and framed union demands that included universal suffrage and land reform. Sensing a threat from below, on July 7, 1851, Thrane and several other leaders were arrested in a large-scale police action that easily crushed any incipient revolt. Thrane and 132 other union members were arrested and sent to prison in 1855. After serving eight years, Thrane resumed his organizing efforts but with little success and, frustrated, he emigrated to the United States in 1862.

Upon arrival, he immediately resumed his radical politics among Norwegian immigrants including the editorship of two socialist newspapers, public speaking and

writing populist plays, including some satirizing the Lutheran Church. The latter prompted church leaders to condemn his socialist ideas further diminishing his radical project. After once having seen so much potential in his adopted country and having urged others to seek a new life there, Thorne became thoroughly disenchanted with American society and its government. He was prescient in predicting that the United States would never be “The Shining City on a Hill,” or the “Citadel of Democracy” admired across the world. Thrane died in Eau Claire, Wisconsin in 1890 and later, the Norwegian Labor Party referred to him as one of its founding fathers and today monument honoring him sits in his hometown of Drammen, Norway.³⁵

They dwelt on the present and future as land takers often do, and they rarely probed the past or questioned laws that privileged them and disadvantaged others.

In retrospect, if anyone should have recognized that the Indian was, in legal scholar Felix Cohen’s words “the miner’s canary” in flagging the sham of American democracy it would have been Marcus Thrane. However, I searched the record in vain for even a passing reference to this vexing indictment of “liberty and equality for all” and found only a glaring moral blind spot. However, can I say with conviction that I would have acted differently?

The second example is GAA PAA (Press Forward) the prominent Norwegian-language socialist newspaper in Minnesota. In an important article, the noted Scandinavian studies expert Odd Lovoll described GAA PAA thusly: “The collective life of the Norwegian-American community can be viewed through the prism of this socialist organ” and the paper’s editorial position was that Norwegian farmers were the natural allies of the working class “...in the battle to defeat capitalism.”³⁶ All the more striking to find that any concern for the indigenous population never surfaced in any issue of the paper, perhaps early evidence of colonized minds, including socialist ones.

Parenthetically, I should mention that growing up in North Dakota I was always proud of the state’s history of agrarian radicalism which began in the 1880s. In 1918, the Nonpartisan League (NPL) won all three branches of government and immediately enacted its program of “state socialism,” easily the most progressive in the entire country. Concurrently, voices across the board cried out against farmers and laborers being exploited by bankers, Twin City grain merchants and the railroads. I mention this because at no point did it occur to me that Indian dispossession was ever mentioned.

What Did They Know and What Does It Matter?

Here we return to the question of whether the vast majority of these first Norwegian-Americans were cognizant of the formal and informal structures, the nefarious mechanisms involved in colonialism, the broken treaties, officially sanctioned

bloodshed, myriad injustices, toxic ideology, and the economic motives of rapacious empire builders? If they were not, is it necessary to parse the meaning of “settlers” and perhaps reconfigure their role as being closer to self-interested pawns manipulated by others?

For me, the answer to questions regarding the ordinary immigrant’s self-perception and view of the Indigenes remains maddeningly problematic. I recently came across sociologist Karen V. Hanson’s inestimably valuable book, *Encounter on the Great Plains*, the focus of which is Scandinavian immigrants to North Dakota from 1890–1930. These settlers included some of her ancestors who’d settled on Indian Reservation land near Devil’s Lake and although their circumstances were not identical, her take on them is as follows:

Norwegians like my great-grandmother did not come to be settler colonialists or to usurp the place of others. They deeply resented having been colonized by Danes and Swedes and could not conceive of themselves as occupying an oppressive position in a foreign country. As newcomers, immigrants were searching desperately for a place to make a home: they were steered onto the reservation enterprise by forces largely beyond their control and outside their kin. With vivid memories of the suffering endured in Norway and Sweden and the sacrifices made during migration, they judged themselves and their descendants worthy of the land... They dwelt on the present and future as land takers often do, and they rarely probed the past or questioned laws that privileged them and disadvantaged others.³⁷

As I began delving further into the history I found contrary opinions among elite opinion shapers, those farther up the social hierarchy. For the area where my grandparents settled, I came across this official history of Stearns County, Minnesota which contained a telling excerpt:

What title did the Indian have to the land? Why should the Indian be considered the owner of the land? Just because he occupied it first? One would judge that by the highest ethical standards the superior civilization has the right to the land.

And then, this statement about the meager sums frequently paid for the land:

The Indian, this simple child of nature has been given a fortune which he could not care for... If the Indian had used wisely what our government has paid them, every man, woman and child of the race today would be well-to-do. (William Bell Mitchell, History of Stearns County, Minnesota, 1915)

We also have Anders Bo Rasmussen’s meticulous, indispensable research which strongly suggests that the Scandinavian immigrant elite, including opinion shapers like newspaper editors, historians and Civil War officers “transplanted Old World perceptions of class and race to the New World, which, in turn, helped to inform how Scandinavians immigrants confronted the post-war reality of slavery’s abolition.” The very first edition of the Norwegian-language newspaper, *The Fatherland*, described the new American republic as a “glorious institution in accordance with human and divine law” that was created “on liberty and equality.” Articles like these were widely shared in Norway, especially in rural areas.

Rasmussen makes a compelling case that many Norwegian immigrants arrived with preconceived perceptions of white men “at the top of a racial hierarchy,” who deserved a higher rung on the “agricultural aristocratic ladder.” They resisted Black people having equal opportunities in the Northern labor market and believed “whiteness separated them from what they described as a “lower class of people.”³⁸ Soon, it was no contest between egalitarian ideals and economic opportunities for whites. This view is reinforced by Terje Mikael Hasle Joranger, Curator of the Norwegian Emigrant Museum in Oslo and a widely acknowledged expert on the subject. In his generous response to my inquiry, he wrote:

In my research I have come across very few references to America in letters, for example, showing any sign of remorse or thoughts connected to land-taking seized in an improper manner from indigenes. There is a great silence connected to references to the indigenous population among Norwegian immigrants in letters, diaries, and reminiscences. References to land in letters are to a large extent tied to concrete mention of land prices of government land, to heads of cattle, and to the growth of various crops.

Joranger continues that the letters largely reflected a concern of practical matters and thinking about how to improve his lot. These individuals “were not looking back in order to judge any harm done to the indigenous settlers.”³⁹

A related explanation comes from Hanson’s aforementioned research. Drawing on 130 oral interviews and fifteen years of archival research, Hanson concludes that these early immigrants were not consciously “settler colonialists” but were, nevertheless indispensable to the colonialist state’s imperial expansionist project. In short, they unwittingly solved the government’s “Indian problem.” Indeed, by 1929, Scandinavians owned more reservation land than the Lakotas.

Hanson’s search was prompted, in part, by trying to come to terms with her “troubled conscience” over a past that privileged her at the expense of others. Her observation about Scandinavians surely applies to virtually everyone of immigrant descent in the United States: “Scandinavians past and present have eluded the thorny past by misrepresenting it or by living uncomfortably with their personal or ancestral history.”⁴⁰ Given only those two choices, my sense is that misrepresentation still prevails, leavened with heavy doses of denial to reduce the discomfort level. However, this essay suggests that filling a gaping lacuna of ignorance with the actual facts regarding the past might open a third choice and I now turn to sketching out more of that context.

Demythologizing History and Decolonizing Our Minds

Consistent with the abiding concern of another analyst looking into this past, my motive has been “...to understand the ongoing processes that have shaped our world... The predicaments in which we find ourselves derive in part from the history of colonial conquest, slavery, imperial warfare, and the inequalities that emerged from this history we might discern the scope, force, direction and likelihood of the change ahead—and be guided by the example of our ancestors.”⁴¹

Put another way, believing the “personal is political,” I began this exploration with a combination of personal and political activist motives. On the one hand, I was uncomfortable with the lacuna about my ancestral background and wanted some resolution—wherever that might lead. On the other, would an objective understanding contribute to greater clarity and utility regarding my existing political commitments? At this point, after substantially enlarging the scope of my inquiry, it feels as if I’ve tentatively arrived at a productive intersection of the two concerns.

By now it’s apparent to the reader that I’m ambivalent about portraying my Norwegian-American ancestors with the broad, often pejorative brush of “settler colonialist” as the last word on the subject. My sense is that there remains a larger, more politically propitious perspective that’s routinely overlooked or avoided. At the same time, I’ve been sensitive to Gerald Horne’s accusation that many hypocritical analysts have avoided giving sufficient attention to his assertion that after being “deputized,” European settlers became accessories in victimizing the indigenous.⁴²

Trying to assess degrees of moral culpability is both unavoidable and necessary in terms of advancing our political understanding with an eye on the future. For radicals like Roxanne Dunbar-Ortiz, the capitalist state bears the major responsibility whereas for many conventional historians, settler colonialism operated from the bottom up. For example, in one recent book which was fulsomely praised in establishment circles and was a National Book Award Finalist, the author makes much of newcomers in the 1830s being enthusiastic exterminators and being “too avaricious” to allow indigenous people to remain. And he almost offhandedly contends that a consistent application of the Republic’s “radical revolutionary values” could

Their complicity, if that’s the proper word, is that they functioned as foot soldiers to the unceasing capitalist logic of elimination, in service to a merciless capitalist logic from which they initially benefited.

have avoided this outcome altogether.⁴³ Again, I could not find a negative word about “capitalism” in this 396-page tome and perhaps needless to mention, mythical feel-good origin myths about the country are simply taken for granted. Most historians simply evade, dismiss or gloss over the entire matter.

Where so many mainstream writers miss the mark is that whereas dispossession was a zero-sum game, these would-be settlers, mostly peasants, were fleeing feudalism at home. It may seem a distinction without a difference, but there is no evidence suggesting they arrived here with the conscious intent of exploiting the indigenous population for economic gain. Their complicity, if that’s the proper word, is that they

functioned as foot soldiers to the unceasing capitalist logic of elimination, in service to a merciless capitalist logic from which they initially benefited. Horne argues that for these settler recruits, land was their “combat pay” for serving as white invaders. Again, another reading of this period suggests that, indeed, a cross-class convergence of interests occurred but only one partner was dimly aware, if that, of being used as an indispensable tool in establishing the property state for private capital accumulation while also serving elite interests in offsetting the vast number of slaves in the country, the “enemy within” feared by the existing polity. If so, I don’t believe it’s exonerating the settlers to recalibrate the term “settler colonialist” when applied to them. Building on earlier discussion, I’m suggesting that it’s impossible to arrive at a meaningful answer to my overall inquiry or draw any useful lessons without engaging the work of some of the revisionist critics who have convincingly undermined comfortable American origin myths about liberty and equality.

Regrettably, many people, including most scholars and some of the self-identified left insist on portraying the American Revolution as besieged patriotic colonists, forthrightly standing up against British economic tyranny, a glorious confirmation of U.S. exceptionalism. One of countless examples is Joseph J. Ellis, who won a Pulitzer Prize for his book, “Founding Fathers” Ellis recounts that “No less an authority than George Washington observed at the end of that any historian who managed to write an accurate account of the war for independence would be accused of writing fiction.”⁴⁴ Washington was not wrong about the fictional accounts, only just how far they would depart from the actual truth.

Ellis’s own fawning account of Washington would qualify as he extolled the countless virtuous of the “brothers” as men who would win the title for “The Greatest Generation” hands down. According to Ellis and countless other myth-making historians, the great activity of this revolutionary generation was their devotion to popular sovereignty and their “common sense of purpose.”⁴⁵ The transparent truth is that the American Revolution was “[T]he first chapter in an inter-imperial war between Great Britain and its dissident elites in North America” and also the advent of American imperial warfare.⁴⁶

We know that as early as 1760, less than five hundred men in just five colonial cities controlled most of the shipping, banking, mining, manufacturing and commerce on the eastern seaboard. In truth, our venerable Founding Fathers were slave owners, wealthy men who wanted a system that would further their interests.⁴⁷ Founding Father Alexander Hamilton (subject of a recent, disingenuous Broadway musical) bought and sold slaves for his wife’s family, owned slaves himself and spoke about Native-Americans as aggressive “savages.” In her new book, Dunbar-Ortiz includes Stanford law professor and historian Gregory Ablavsky’s observation that Hamilton and his fellow federalists resolved to “solve the problem of Indian affairs by committing the federal state to empowering, not restraining the inexorable westward tide.”⁴⁸

Many of the Founders, including George Washington, were land speculators and long before King George III issued the Proclamation of 1763, forbidding settlements west of the Appalachian Mountains, these men had begun making claims on this native land. They were eager to push forward into Indian territory. Jumping ahead

a bit and in what was already *a fait accompli*, in the 1783 Treaty of Paris, the British agreed to recognize American independence all the way to the Mississippi River.

These wealthy slave owners wanted a system that furthered their interests and fifty-six of these noteworthy members of the propertied class later signed the Declaration of Independence. All of these famous “patriots” had only contempt for actual democracy, feared it and recoiled from it. As one American historian corrects the historical record, “The American state, even in its earliest incarnations, was more concerned with limiting popular democracy than securing and expanding it.”⁴⁹

Here it’s imperative to remember that Europeans did not think of themselves as “white people” until it became an arbitrary social construction and to the extent that my ancestors did it was a relatively recent phenomenon. In earlier times, people saw themselves as members of a clan, tribe, religion or geographic area. And when the transformation began, its contingency was tied to its service to England and later the United States’ exploitation of “the other,” including Blacks and Indians. Gerald Horne adroitly depicts the latter transformation with only a trace of hyperbole when he writes:

All of a sudden when crossing the Atlantic, in a narrow manner that would make Madison Avenue blush, all are rebranded as ‘white’ which subsumes many of the tensions, ethnic and class among them, in a new monetized and militarized ‘identity politics’ of whiteness based on expropriation of the indigenous and enslavement of the Africans.⁵⁰

In two works, Horne demonstrates how, since the sixteenth century, whiteness/white supremacy “became the ideological glue allowing disparate European nations and peoples to justify confiscating resources, land and labor from those on the darker side of the color line.”⁵¹ This was racial capitalism and the operative words here are “ideological glue.” As noted earlier, this tool was honed to perfection by European and later the American capitalist class in “settling” North America.

I’m acutely aware of accusations of class reductionism that are lodged by apologists for identity politics. In response, I don’t deny for a moment that the arbitrary social construct of race, its sociology, exerted and continues to impact people’s lives

All of the famous “patriots” had only contempt for actual democracy, feared it, and recoiled from it.

in hideously consequential ways. And, of course, working people of color are simultaneously exploited and suppressed. However, as exceptional political scientist Victor Wallis reminds us, “Of all the non-class or cross-class identities, race is the one that comes closest to having been created in the service of class interest.” And further, concentrated class power collectively suppresses all intersectional constituencies.⁵² Finally, I would be hard pressed to come up with a better, consciously created, ruling class tool than white identity. It’s integral to the sleight of hand deceit, the manufactured ignorance that racial capitalism employs to conceal the underlying brutality of

our capitalist order. I'm suggesting we make a serious error if we mistake the means of domination for the end.⁵³

The incipient and then full-fledged capitalist state project required what David Harvey, in a different context, described as "accumulation by dispossession."⁵⁴ Colonization was not peripheral but was, along with slavery, a central pillar in the development of capitalism in the modern United States. This required the dispossession of the Indigenes, followed, as we've seen, by erasure through cultural assimilation. A line can be run from crucial moments in the sixteenth century on to Marx's "so-called primitive accumulation," which he illustrated by the clearing and privatizing of the commons, on to Boston's merchant class rebellion against the monarchy, to dispossession of the Indigenous tribes which also was the genesis of the U.S. military establishment and finally, extending to the U.S. empire spanning the globe today and which is enforced by massive direct violence.

Ripping off surplus value via dispossession of Indigenous tribes initially appears problematic because it doesn't directly involve wage-labor exploitation. However, as Couhart and others clarify, although there were early efforts to enslave Indians, colonization was "uniquely oriented toward the seizure of indigenous lands, rather than the labor-power of Indigenes." However, "...the ends have always remained the same: to shore up continued access to Indigenous people's territory for the purpose of state formation, settlement and capitalist development."⁵⁵ Hence, I would argue that only an intentionally tortured reading of Marx would deny a close relationship between primitive capital accumulation and land dispossession. If we think of settler colonialism as a stage in a long-term project there's no contradiction.

Horne asserts that for these settler recruits, the "free land" was their combat pay for serving as white invaders. Perhaps deviating slightly from Horne, I'm suggesting that another reading of this history divulges a cross-class convergence of interests where only one partner was only dimly aware, if that, of being an indispensable tool in establishing a private property state for private capital accumulation—primitive accumulation—while also serving the elite goal objective of offsetting the vast number of slaves, the feared "enemy within" to the existing polity.

Howard Zinn and Gerald Horne are two preeminent, groundbreaking historians who've helped to further our understanding. I have no reason to believe that Zinn would disagree with Horne's assessment that 1776 marks the date when nascent capitalists "pulled the ultimate coup and exhibited a novel display of patriotism by ousting London altogether from the mainland colonies south of Canada, while convincing the deluded and otherwise naive (to this very day) that this naked grab for land, slaves and profit was somehow a Great Leap Forward for humanity."⁵⁶ Horne goes on to refer to the United States as Great Britain's "revolting spawn," the "bastard child" determined to establish its own empire. And in 150 years it went to become Britain's global capitalist rival.

In support of my assertion, here are a few excerpts from Zinn's magisterial book, *A People's History of the United States*, in which he cogently explains that over a relatively short period of time, the colonial elite was able to:

...take over land, profits and power from the British empire. In the process they could hold back a number of potential rebellions and create a consensus of popular support for the rule of a new, privileged leadership. When we look at the American Revolution in that way it was a work of genius.

[The Declaration of Independence] was a wonderfully useful device, the language of liberty and equality which could unite just enough whites to fight the Revolution, without ending either slavery or inequality.

...the rebellion against British rule allow a certain group of the colonial elite to replace those loyal to England, give some benefits to small holders and leave poor white working people and tenant farmers in very much the same situation.⁵⁷

Prof. Horne's more recent work complements Zinn while devoting considerably more attention to events long preceding the Declaration in 1776 and even, 1492. In his 2018 book, Horne cogently outlines the genesis of emerging capitalism in England as the "dawning of the apocalypse for non-European people." The most pivotal moment is the much misinterpreted "Glorious Revolution of 1688" when the propertied classes triumphed over absolute monarchy. The former wanted access to the "Crown's control over the wildly lucrative African slave trade which ultimately provided the wherewithal for the overthrow of the reign of the monarch in 1776." Horne doesn't mince words in concluding this "blatant power and money grab by merchants was then dressed up in the finery of liberty and freedom, as the bourgeois revolution was conceived in a crass and crude act of staggering hypocrisy." As such, "...1776 completed the apocalypse began in the seventeenth century."⁵⁸

I'm asserting that a narrow focus on settlers per se, tends to divert attention from the capitalist project and its identical state agency.

In an earlier book, Horne depicts two events that explain why the colonists finally broke with the Mother Country and neither flatters the consensus origin story of the nation's founding. The first was a judgement of the English Court of King's Bench in June, 1772. This was the issuance of the Somerset Decision by the Chief Justice of England, Lord Mansfield and involved James Somerset who was a slave then residing in England after being brought there by his owner from Boston. Somerset was about to be sold to a plantation in Jamaica but Mansfield declared that "The state of slavery is of such a nature it is incapable of being introduced on any reason, moral or political...and therefore the black [James Somerset] must be discharged" from his enslavement. Although Mansfield offered no judgement on overseas territories of the British Empire, the future Patriots, mostly slave owners and slave traders, feared that Somerset abolition in Britain and set a precedent applicable to the thirteen colonies, thus jeopardizing their existing and future financial gains.⁵⁹

The second event that further heightened anxiety and finally tipped the scales in favor of the colonial elites breaking with Britain happened in November, 1775 when Lord Dunmore in Virginia offered to not only liberate but arm North American slaves. According to Horne, with that proclamation, Dunmore “entered a pre-existing maelstrom of [colonial] insecurity about slavery and London’s intentions.”⁶⁰ It also “effectively barred any further possibility of rebel conciliation with London.”⁶⁰ In short, the “Patriot” portion of the colonial elite was petrified, and not without cause, that the British would cease supporting the right to own slaves in the thirteen colonies. In the words of historian Colin Calloway, the colonial elite “saw tyranny in Britain’s interference with their ability to make a [financial] killing in the West.”⁶¹ What remained was to rally ordinary people to support separation from the Mother Country. In pursuit of that end Horne points to an often-overlooked statement within the Declaration of Independence. In the list of grievances against the King we find:

He has excited domestic insurrections among us, and has endeavored to bring on the inhabitants of our frontiers, the merciless Indian savages, whose rule of warfare, is an indistinguishable destruction of all ages, sexes and conditions.

Through a combination of Jefferson’s lofty rhetoric and disingenuous appeals such as this one, the “rebels” were able to prevail in the propaganda wars, convince “enough” of the remaining skeptics, and break with the Mother Country in 1776. After bourgeois democracy was established the former “Patriots,” among other pursuits, methodically proceeded to extirpate the indigenous population. Notably, my ancestors began arriving some one hundred years later.

In any event, even as they wittingly or unwittingly collaborated in dispossession, most settlers would soon become members of the working class and victims of the merciless logic of capitalism, “subject to the tyranny of the market in its stead.”⁶² Wealth was extracted from their labor and their share of the colonial booty declined in favor of economic elites. Lest I be misunderstood, I’m not for a moment suggesting equivalency for what befell blacks under slavery and subsequently under racial capitalism and the plight of the white working class. I’m asserting that a narrow focus on settlers per se, tends to divert attention from the capitalist project itself and its identical state agency. Finally, I would argue that we’re further from grasping the dynamics of that project today—from realizing class consciousness—than our working class ancestors were at the time.

In Lieu of a Final Conclusion

I began this project, in part, to investigate what it means to be a descendant of Norwegian-American settlers. It remains a gray area because we don’t know for certain if they knew they were the “boots on the ground” for the capitalist state project of dispossession. But, if they did know, would it have made any difference? The word “silence” appears with regularity in writings about Scandinavian self-awareness about encounters with indigenes in Minnesota and North Dakota or postulating about why the land was available and perhaps that approximates a certain unease or an almost total self-denial.

Reaching a definitive conclusion on the above is less important to me now than it was at the outset of my search. As I expanded the inquiry to encompass the power

forces of capital accumulation, and the identity, motives and methods of the penultimate colonizers, these assumed pride of place in terms of explanatory power. I don’t think it’s exculpatory to suggest that the settler’s role paled in significance. The settlers were instrumentalized on the ground and functioned, in Horne’s term, as “handmaidens.” As such, refocusing the familiar settler-indigenous dichotomy through the lens of class analysis and objective historical contextualization, reveals a more plausible picture.

When I was still teaching undergraduates, I often said that one reason to study history, arguably the most important one, is to discover that it’s an illusion to believe that certain events were inevitable, as somehow preordained. At various interstices, choices are made that if made differently can lead to vastly different outcomes. In that vein, in response to a question I posed to noted historian Steven Hahn about the prospects he foresaw for serious political change, Hahn wrote, “Change is not linear by any means. I think the arc of the universe is a very long one, and the struggle is over which way to pull it. There is no natural bent. For the most part it has bent toward injustice. But we need to think it can be bent toward justice—and that is a struggle worth having and participating in.”⁶³

Finally, noted activist and author Roxanne Dunbar-Ortiz draws our attention to the words of the late indigenous scholar Jack Forbes who “always stressed that while living persons are not responsible for what their ancestors did, they are responsible for the society they live in, which is a product of the past.”⁶⁴ This is especially germane for those who, after a certain age, have had the luxury of time, education and access to a wide spectrum of information. For them, ignorance about the past is no excuse.

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As always, I’m grateful to have Kathleen Kelly as my in-house editor and co-conspirator.



A poor settler's sod house.

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Double Deformation: Capital v. Nature & Humanity

MICHAEL A. LEBOWITZ

The exploitation of workers is at the core of capitalism. It explains capital's drive to divide workers in order to grow. Exploitation is the source of the inequality characteristic of capitalism. To fight inequality, we must fight capitalist exploitation. However, inequality is only one aspect of capitalism. In and by itself, exploitation is inadequate to grasp the effects of capital's drive and thus the products of capitalism. Focus upon exploitation is one-sided because you do not know the enemy unless you understand the double deformation inherent in capitalism.

Recall that human beings and Nature are the ultimate inputs into production. In capitalist production, they serve specifically as means for the purpose of the growth of capital. The result is deformation—capitalistically-transformed Nature and capitalistically-transformed human beings. Capitalist production, Marx stressed, “only develops the technique and the degree of combination of the social process of production by simultaneously undermining the original sources of all wealth—the soil and the worker.”

But why?

The Deformation of Nature

By itself, Nature is characterized by a metabolic process through which it converts various inputs and transforms these into the basis for its reproduction. In his discussion of the production of wheat, for example, Marx identified a “vegetative or physiological process” involving the seeds and “various chemical ingredients supplied by the manure, salts contained in the soil, water, air, light.”

Through this process, inorganic components are “assimilated by the organic components and transformed into organic material.” Their form is changed in this metabolic process, from inorganic to organic through what Marx called “the expenditure of nature.” Also, part of the “universal metabolism of nature” is the further transformation of organic components, their deterioration and dying through their “consumption by elemental forces.”

In this way, the conditions for rebirth (for example, the “vitality of the soil”) are themselves products of this metabolic process. “The seed becomes the unfolded plant, the blossom fades, and so forth.” Birth, death, and renewal are moments characteristic of the “metabolism prescribed by the natural laws of life itself.”

This universal metabolism of Nature, however, must be distinguished from the relation in which a human being “mediates, regulates and controls the metabolism between himself and nature.” That labor process involves the “appropriation of what exists in nature for the requirements of man. It is the universal condition for the metabolic interaction between man and nature.” This “ever-lasting nature-imposed condition of human existence,” Marx pointed out, is “common to all forms of society in which human beings live.”

As we have indicated, however, under capitalist relations of production, the pre-conceived goal of production is the growth of capital. The particular metabolic process that occurs in this case is one in which human labor and Nature are converted into surplus value, the basis for that growth.

Accordingly, rather than a process that begins with “man and his labor on one side, nature and its materials on the other,” in capitalist relations the starting point is capital, and “the labor process is a process between things the capitalist has purchased, things which belong to him.” It is “appropriation of what exists in nature for the requirements” not of man but of capital.

There is, as noted, “exploration of the earth in all directions” for a single purpose—to find new sources of raw materials to ensure the generation of profits. Nature, “the universal material for labor,” the “original larder” for human existence, is here a means not for human existence but for capital's existence.

As we have seen, while capital's tendency to grow by leaps and bounds comes up against a barrier insofar as plant and animal products are “subject to certain organic laws involving naturally determined periods of time”, capital constantly drives beyond each barrier it faces.

However, there is a barrier it does not escape. Marx noted, for example, that “the entire spirit of capitalist production, which is oriented towards the most immediate monetary profit—stands in contradiction to agriculture, which has to concern itself with the whole gamut of permanent conditions of life required by the chain of human generations.” Indeed, the very nature of production under capitalist relations violates “the metabolic interaction between man and the earth,” it produces “an irreparable rift in the interdependent process of social metabolism, a metabolism prescribed by the natural laws of life itself.”

That “irreparable” metabolic rift that Marx described is neither a short-term disturbance nor unique to agriculture. The “squandering of the vitality of the soil” is a paradigm for the way in which the “metabolism prescribed by the natural laws of life itself” is violated under capitalist relations of production.

In fact, there is nothing inherent in agricultural production that leads to that “squandering of the vitality of the soil.” On the contrary, Marx pointed out that a society can bequeath the earth “in an improved state to succeeding generations.” But this requires an understanding that “agriculture forms a mode of production *sui generis*, because the organic process is involved, in addition to the mechanical and chemical process, and the natural reproduction process is merely controlled and guided.” The same is true, too, in the case of fishing, hunting, and forestry. Maintenance and improvement of the vitality of the soil and of other sectors dependent upon organic conditions requires the recognition of the necessity for “systematic restoration as a regulative law of social production.”

With every increase in capitalist production, there are growing demands upon the natural environment, and the tendency to exhaust Nature's larder and to generate unabsorbed and unutilizable waste is not at all limited to the metabolic rift that Marx described with respect to capitalist agriculture.

Thus, Marx indicated that “extractive industry (mining is the most important) is likewise an industry *sui generis*, because no reproduction process whatever takes place in it, at least not one under our control or known to us,” and, he noted as well “the exhaustion of forests, coal and iron mines, and so on.” Given its preoccupation with its need to grow, capital has no interest in the contradiction between its logic and the “natural laws of life itself.” The contradiction between its drive for infinite growth and a finite, limited earth is not a concern because for capital there is always another source of growth to be found.

Like a vampire, it seeks the last possible drop of blood and does not worry about keeping its host alive.

Accordingly, since capital does not worry about “simultaneously undermining the original sources of all wealth — the soil and the worker,” sooner or later it destroys both. Marx’s comment with respect to capital’s drive to drain every ounce of energy from the worker describes capital’s relation to the natural world precisely:

“*Après moi le deluge!*” is the watchword of every capitalist and every capitalist nation. Capital therefore takes no account of the health and the length of life of the worker, unless society forces it to do so.”

We are seeing the signs of that approaching deluge. Devastating wildfires, droughts, powerful hurricanes, warming oceans, floods, rising sea levels, pollution, pandemics, disappearing species, etc., are becoming commonplace—but there is nothing in capital’s metabolic process that would check that. If, for example, certain materials become scarce and costly, capital will not scale back and accept less or no growth; rather, it will scour the earth to search for new sources and substitutes.

Can society prevent the crisis of the earth system, the deluge? Not currently. The ultimate deformation of Nature is the prospect because the second deformation makes it easier to envision the end of the world than the end of capitalism.

The Deformation of Human Beings

Human beings are not static and fixed. Rather, they are a work in process because they develop as the result of their activity. They change themselves as they act in and upon the world. In this respect there are always two products of human activity—the change in circumstances and the change in the human being. In the very act of producing, Marx commented, “the producers change, too, in that they bring out new qualities in themselves, develop themselves in production, transform themselves, develop new powers and new ideas, new modes of intercourse, new needs and new language.”

In the process of producing, the worker “acts upon external nature and changes it, and in this way he simultaneously changes his own nature.”

In this “self-creation of man as a process,” the character of that human product flows from the nature of that productive activity. Under particular circumstances, that process can be one in which people are able to develop their capacities in an all-rounded way.

As Marx put it, “when the worker co-operates in a planned way with others, he strips off the fetters of his individuality, and develops the capabilities of his species”. In such a situation, associated producers may expend “their many different forms of

labor-power in full self-awareness as one single social labor force”, and the means of production are “there to satisfy the worker’s own need for development.”

For example, if workers democratically decide upon a plan, work together to achieve its realization, solve problems which emerge and shift in this process from activity to activity, they engage in a constant succession of acts which expand their capacities. For workers in this situation, there is the “absolute working-out of his creative potentialities,” the “complete working out of the human content,” the “development of all human powers as such the end in itself.”

Collective activity under these relations produces “free individuality, based on the universal development of individuals and on their subordination of their communal, social productivity as their social wealth.” In the society of the future, Marx concluded, the productive forces of people will have “increased with the all-round development of the individual, and all the springs of co-operative wealth flow more abundantly”.

But that’s not the character of activity under capitalist relations of production, where “it is not the worker who employs the conditions of his work, but rather the reverse, the conditions of work employ the worker.” While we know how central exploitation is from the perspective of capital, consider the effects upon workers of what capital does to ensure that exploitation. We’ve seen how capital constantly attempts to separate workers and, indeed, fosters antagonism among them (the “secret” of its success); how capital introduces changes in production that divides them further, intensifies the production process and expands the reserve army that fosters competition.

What’s the effect? Marx pointed out that “all means for the development of production” under capitalism “distort the worker into a fragment of a man,” degrade him and “alienate him from the intellectual potentialities of the labor process”. In Capital, he described the mutilation, the impoverishment, the “crippling of body and mind” of the worker “bound hand and foot for life to a single specialized operation” that occurs in the division of labor characteristic of the capitalist process of manufacturing.

But did the subsequent development of machinery end that crippling of workers? Marx’s response was that under capitalist relations such developments complete the “separation of the intellectual faculties of the production process from manual labor.” Thinking and doing become separate and hostile, and “every atom of freedom, both in bodily and in intellectual activity” is lost.

In short, a particular type of person is produced in capitalism. Producing within capitalist relations is what Marx called a process of a “complete emptying-out,” “total alienation,” the “sacrifice of the human end-in-itself to an entirely external end”. Indeed, the worker is so alienated that, though working with others, he “actually treats the social character of his work, its combination with the work of others for a common goal, as a power that is alien to him.”

In this situation, in order to fill the vacuum of our lives, we need things—we are driven to consume. In addition to producing commodities and capital itself, thus, capitalism produces a fragmented, crippled human being, whose enjoyment consists in possessing and consuming things. More and more things. Capital constantly gen-

erates new needs for workers, and it is upon this, Marx noted, that “the contemporary power of capital rests.”

In short, every new need for capitalist commodities is a new link in the golden chain that links workers to capital.

Accordingly, rather than producing a working class that wants to put an end to capitalism, capital tends to produce the working class it needs, workers who treat capitalism as common sense. As Marx concluded:

“The advance of capitalist production develops a working class which by education, tradition and habit looks upon the requirements of that mode of production as self-evident natural laws. The organization of the capitalist process of production, once it is fully developed, breaks down all resistance.”

To this, he added that capital’s generation of a reserve army of the unemployed “sets the seal on the domination of the capitalist over the worker.” That constant generation of a relative surplus population of workers means, Marx argued, that wages are “confined within limits satisfactory to capitalist exploitation, and lastly, the social dependence of the worker on the capitalist, which is indispensable, is secured.”

Accordingly, Marx concluded that the capitalist can rely upon the worker’s “dependence on capital, which springs from the conditions of production themselves, and is guaranteed in perpetuity by them.”

However, while it is possible that workers may remain socially dependent upon capital in perpetuity, that doesn’t mean that capital’s incessant growth can continue in perpetuity. In fact, given that workers deformed by capital accept capital’s requirement to grow “as self-evident natural laws,” their deformation supports the deformation of Nature.

In turn, the increase in flooding, drought and other extreme climate changes and resulting mass migrations which are the product of the deformation of Nature intensify divisions and antagonism among workers. The crisis of the earth system and the crisis of humanity are one.

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A Conversation About Sandinistas and Contras, Thirty Years Later

LENNY FLANK

In 2016 I was visiting the Military Museum in Naples FL. It’s a typical little veterans museum, the same type found in many cities across the country, with display cases full of uniforms, medals, perhaps some period weapons, and model tanks and airplanes.

But tucked away in a corner I was surprised to see a display case labeled “The War in Nicaragua”. I assumed it referred to the US invasion during the 1930’s, which is rather an unusual subject for museums like this—they tend to focus mostly on WW2, Vietnam, and the Persian Gulf/Afghanistan.

Looking inside, I got an even bigger surprise—it wasn’t about the 1930’s invasion at all, but about the Contra War, in which US-backed insurgents tried to overthrow the leftist Sandinista Government in Nicaragua during the 1980’s. This was a subject near to my heart—the interventions in Nicaragua and El Salvador were enormously controversial and there was a thriving anti-war movement at the time opposing US involvement, of which I was a part. I had also traveled to Nicaragua in February 1988 as part of an anti-war group.

So, I casually mentioned to the volunteer who was working the museum that I had been in Nicaragua during the Contra War. And to my utter shock, he answered that he had been there too—he was one of the US military personnel that had been secretly sent to Central America to help train the Contras and to gather intelligence for a possible US invasion. The items in the display case that told the story, were his.

So, for the next hour, we each pulled up a chair and, in a friendly debate, re-fought a fight from thirty years ago...

In 1979, the Sandinista Front for National Liberation (FSLN), a conglomeration of left-leaning guerrilla groups that had been fighting in the Nicaraguan mountains for years, defeated the forces of US-backed dictator Anastasia Somoza and entered Managua in triumph. US President Jimmy Carter, who had made “human rights” a central issue of his foreign policy and who had previously been making unsuccessful efforts behind the scenes to push Somoza to step down and hold free elections, shed no tears for the dictatorship, but also had to face Cold War realities—the Cubans and Soviets had been backing the Sandinista guerrillas, as they were also backing insurgencies in El Salvador and Guatemala. Carter tried to keep the new Sandinista Government out of the Soviet orbit by offering economic aid; at the same time, he cut off economic aid to the El Salvadoran Government as punishment for its numerous human rights violations.

In 1981, however, Ronald Reagan took office, and US policy in Central America veered sharply. In Reagan’s eyes, the Sandinistas were mere tools of the USSR, and they required a military response. With US funding, weapons and support, an

insurgent movement was organized called the “Contras”, consisting mostly of former members of Somoza’s military. The Contras operated from bases in Honduras and Costa Rica, conducting cross-border raids into Nicaragua to hit soft targets before running back across the border.

For the next eight years, there would be political battles in Congress over US support for the Contras. Meanwhile, the largest anti-war movement since Vietnam appeared in the US—the Central American peace movement opposed US intervention, and denounced US support both for the Contras and for military dictatorships in El Salvador and Guatemala who were slaughtering their own people. We also opposed any US military invasion in Central America. When the US refused to admit refugees from the war-torn countries, the “sanctuary” movement appeared, which illegally smuggled refugees into American cities.

At that time, I was a 20-something activist in Pennsylvania who was active in both the Central America peace movement and the sanctuary movement. In February 1988, just a few months before the ceasefire, I went to Nicaragua as part of a short-term delegation with the anti-war group Witness for Peace—I was in Managua, Matagalpa, Rio Blanco and Bocana de Paiwas. The Contras had done quick hit-and-run raids on Paiwas while I was there, coming in at night, firing off a couple RPGs and machine-gun bursts, then running off into the jungle. When I got back, I became a speaker for local organizations about the war. I also got a visit from the FBI.

The museum volunteer, meanwhile, was a 30-something in the US Army intelligence branch. Sometime in the 1980’s (he was a bit circumspect about specifics, partly because he wasn’t sure if anything was still classified) he was selected as a “training officer”, whose job it would be to instruct the Contra forces how to use the weapons they were being provided with. The US was sending a small number of old M-14 rifles to the Contras, but most of the guns they were being given were foreign: many of the AKs captured during the invasion of Grenada went to the Contras, as well as some of the Argentine FN-FALs captured by the British in the Falklands. The Contras were also instructed in the use of Soviet-made RPG-7 rocket-propelled grenades, American LAWs (“Light Anti-tank Weapon” rocket launchers) and Redeye anti-aircraft missiles. He was sent periodically to secret training bases set up in Honduras, where he spent a couple months at a time instructing groups of Contra recruits.

After a time, he was assigned to a new task—intelligence gathering. Under a secret program, American military personnel were sent into Nicaragua from the US as ordinary tourists. They wore civilian clothes and carried cameras and passports. When they saw things that were of specific interest to military intelligence, such as police stations, roadway checkpoints or electrical stations, they would play the tourist and ask some passerby to take a photo of them, carefully posed so that the target of interest was in the background. One of the items on display at the museum was the 35mm camera that the volunteer had used during intelligence-gathering missions in Nicaragua.

When I asked how much the Army knew about the groups of American peace-niks in Nicaragua, he said that they knew where we were all the time, and they would occasionally put an intelligence officer in with the groups. For the most part, they tried to keep the Contras out of areas where they knew there were Americans, since

having a US citizen killed in a Contra attack would cause political difficulties. But very often that wasn’t possible, and many times there were Contra attacks in places where they knew there were Americans. One of the places in Nicaragua that both the volunteer and I had been was the grave of Benjamin Linder, an American peace worker who had been killed during a Contra raid.

Another thing I asked about was the effect that the anti-war movement had on the administration’s plans for a possible invasion. (There were regular anti-war rallies in DC at the time that attracted 75,000 people.) He answered that he wasn’t involved in any of that planning, and that decision was made way above his pay grade, but his own view was that while the anti-war movement had a political effect in the US (the uncomfortable experience of the Vietnam War protests was only twenty years previous), the lack of popular support within Nicaragua for the Contras convinced many in the military that an invasion was not a particularly good idea, and would have left American troops embroiled in a new insurgency which would not have gotten public support back home. In other words, another Vietnam.

He was still unrepentant and remained a supporter of the Reagan Administration’s actions in Central America, and I am still unrepentant and an opponent. For the most part, the reasons we gave each other are still the same reasons we both gave back in the 1980’s. He viewed the Contra War as a heroic effort to prevent the Soviet Union from gaining control of Central America, and I viewed it as yet another in a long string of imperial American interventions in support of brutal dictatorships who supported our interests.

In the end, we shook hands and agreed that, while we remained on different sides, we were both glad that it ended without an invasion.

It was a real blast from the past.

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“The US was even condemned by the World Court for ‘unlawful use of force’—aka international terrorism—and ordered to pay substantial reparations to Nicaragua and to call off its terrorist war. Of course, that was disregarded, and the terror war was escalated.”

—Noam Chomsky, *Consequences of Capitalism*

Interstellar slavery: coming to a planet near you?

RAYMOND NAT TURNER

Plundering our planet, the parasitic capitalist
Class places itself above/apart from nature and
Humanity... And its corporate parrots repeat
Galaxy-colonizing crack pipe claptrap of
billionaire bosses regarding missions of phallic
boy toys sucked up from sweat beads of toilers...

I spoke with Sun Ra and Ra said: "If they arrive
Alive, Hannibal Lecter masks are waiting;
They'll quarantine 30-40 yrs—social-distance
100+ miles until their blood-sucking virus—
Greed—recedes and their penchant for polluting,
Exploiting, trashing planets and peoples is heeled..."

I hippped Ra to visions of Earth's richest man and
Ra busted a rib, doubled over laughing.
He chortled, "Backwards capitalism's light years
Behind the beat—and interstellar slavery ain't happenin'
out here. Why, we'd laugh y'all out the universe if Non-
Interference Inter-Planetary Solidarity wasn't how we fly..."

He said word in the galaxy is that these space colonialist
cowboys are primitive, fecal-minded fools with embalmed
brains—Tax-avoiding terrestrial hustlers who've yet to
Evolve from trashing and treating Earth as if it were their
mine shaft, junkyard, yacht-jet storage space/interplanetary
Plantation...

Ra cried distilled tears over greedy red-orange flames grabbing
at the galaxy; thick black smoke quilts masking
Sun rays and smothering oxygen; a Texas-size plastic patch
covering an ocean's eye; cardboard mattresses in tents popping
up like pastel mushrooms; mile-long food lines; And, of course, cops
and soldiers storming Capitalist Hill

He screamed, "Profiteers poisoning blue gold lending Earth life is
Lunacy! Out here Earth's known as 'the planet of smoking guns and
Mushroom clouds' ringed by bases and police stations where crimson
rivers run; the planet where primitives brandish sticks with triggers
And massacre each other over rectangular rags; the planet that stinks
of crematoriums where Earthlings were barbecued; and human cargo-
laden ships sailed for centuries like clockwork over teary oceans..."

Ra whispered, "I hippped Saturn to Earth, minute I got home...
They said, 'Multiple planets pulled our coats centuries ago. We've
been surveilling Earth for thousands of years. Intelligent life's
appalled at capitalist ignorance/Earthlings' suffering!' Ra winked,
"My dear Brother, Mercury, Mars, Venus, Jupiter, Saturn don't play
that Plymouth Rock shit. Tell those mutha-frackers: Come in peace...
Or leave in...pieces..."

*Raymond Nat Turner is Black Agenda Report's poet in residence and is an accomplished
performing artist. You can find much more of his work at upsurgejazz.com*

should suffice to convince rational people of the dysfunctionality of politics as presently constituted. The case of the state's response to the Covid-19 pandemic is instructive in this regard as well, given the focus on rolling out a vaccine mostly in the Global North and barely any consideration of the sources of the pandemic, such as the economic structures that propel deforestation. Indeed, one could reasonably ask whether the ruling class is even aware of the root cause(s) of the climate crisis. Its failure to manage the system's trajectory should leave no doubt as to its ability to stabilize the climate in the near future.

Fortunately, a global consensus in climate science opinion has emerged that leaves very little doubt about the sources and the nature of the climate crisis and the need to act decisively to reverse the ecocidal trends. The Intergovernmental Panel on Climate Change (IPCC) Reports reflect this consensus. The IPCC was created in 1988 to act as a clearinghouse for synthesizing the relevant scientific literature and to provide policymakers with regular up to date scientific knowledge about climate change.

On August 9, 2021, the IPCC [released its latest Report](#) (the first portion of its Sixth Assessment Report on climate change) issuing a red code warning to humanity. It states: the “scale of recent changes across the climate system as a whole ... are unprecedented over many centuries to many thousands of years;” that “Global warming of 1.5°C and 2°C will be exceeded during the 21st century unless deep reductions in carbon dioxide (CO₂) and other greenhouse gas emissions occur in the coming decades;” that “Many changes due to past and future greenhouse gas emissions are irreversible for centuries to millennia, especially changes in the ocean, ice sheets and global sea level;” that “Low-likelihood outcomes, such as ice sheet collapse, abrupt ocean circulation changes, some compound extreme events and warming substantially larger than the assessed very likely range of future warming cannot be ruled out and are part of risk assessment;” and that “limiting human-induced global warming to a specific level requires limiting cumulative CO₂ emissions, reaching at least net zero CO₂ emissions, along with strong reductions in other greenhouse gas emissions.”

And still [further takeaways](#): the atmospheric CO₂ levels in 2019 were higher than at any time in at least 2 million years; since the last 2,000 years, in no other 50-year period did the earth's average surface temperature rise faster than during the period 1970-2020; since at least the last 3,000 years, in no other century did the global average sea level rise faster than it did during the 20th century.

Another welcome development is that the proportion of people in the US who express concern about the warming of the planet has reached an-all-time [high of 70%](#). That is enough support for the political class to do the right thing had its politics not been tied to the fossil fuel industry in particular and the capitalist class in general and had the US not have a dysfunctional political system. Still, [only one in five persons](#) in the US are at all aware that more than nine out of ten climate scientists concur with the consensus of scientific opinion about the climate crisis.

Of course, an overwhelming consensus of scientific opinion about climate change and its catastrophic consequences does not mean there is certainty that the latter will come to pass nor that everyone will be on board for decisive actions. But here the logic of insurance option should apply: i.e., one doesn't require 100% certainty in order to take out insurance against the remote possibilities of personal catastrophes such as traffic accidents, home fires and so on. The precautionary principle is also relevant here: it states that if a high risk is suspected in an action or concerning a policy and so on, one should take protective measures even before complete scientific proof exists.

There is also the little discussed matter of the growing feelings of hopelessness, despair and anguish especially among the younger generations whose lives will be most affected and unfairly burdened by climate disruptions that threaten human survival as well as the survival of other species, a dreadful legacy of the older generations. For example, [a new international survey](#) of 10,000 young people aged 16 to 25 in 10 different countries, which included the US, India, Nigeria, Australia and the Philippines, found that three out of four believe “The future is frightening,”

while 45% are experiencing “high levels of psychological distress” from climate disruption and lack of governmental action to deal effectively with the growing crisis.

None of the above developments are sufficient in themselves to bring about the necessary changes. The rising public concerns about the warming planet and the extreme anxiety of the young adults have as yet to move the ruling class to act responsibly. The IPCC Reports inform, advise, and urge policymakers to take decisive mitigating actions. Sharing the scientific insights with the public is a component of the fight for climate justice, but climate science literacy isn't sufficient by itself. Nor can we rely on all scientists to act politically. What matters most are (a) a broad and popular movement for a livable future that adopts disruptive forms of politics; (b) a revitalized labor movement that's willing to withdraw labor from the fossil fuel and fossil-fuel-dependent sectors of the economy; and (c) a broader movement to ensure that workers' climate activism and refusal to work do not lower their standard of living. Social imagination is more critical than simply delivering scientific data to the public. The window of opportunity is closing and is confined to the present decade only.

In the US, the Party that loudly proclaimed its belief in science (the Democrats) during the years of Trump as president is now in power, but it is nowhere near taking seriously the latest scientific consensus on climate disruption. No doubt, the Biden administration's climate policy is preferable to Trump's direct assault on the environment. In fact, it's likely the best on offer so far by any previous administration. But, the fact remains that it's far from what is required to avert ecological calamities in the near future. Indeed, the day after the IPCC report, Biden called on OPEC and its allies to increase oil production, to ensure lower fuel prices as we approach the mid-term US elections. The believe-in-science proclamations by the liberal class were, and continue to be, more rhetoric than reality, even as the latest IPCC Report issues a “code red” warning to humanity and urges decisive measures to avoid irreversible and catastrophic consequences. Furthermore, as mentioned above, it does not help either that we are asked to rely on a political system that failed miserably to respond to the Covid-19 pandemic at home with more than 700,000 deaths at the time of writing.

A serious politics will:

- identify the institutional structure of global capitalist order and the unconstrained logic of capital as factors most responsible for destroying the environmental basis of organized human life;
- expose capital's tendency to subsume science under its own narrow logic of accumulation based on exploitation of human labor and nature and thus challenges the instrumentalization of science in service to capital;
- strive to make more people aware of the overwhelming climate science consensus and its implications for the rule of capital;
- combat the fossil fuel industry's projects of denialism by means of which it raises doubts about the dire warnings of the scientific community;
- mobilize the public to engage in disruptive mass actions against the business-as-usual politics and destructive corporate practices;
- challenge empire and militarism, including converting military production to green production; and
- build a labor movement that challenges both the rule of capital and fights for a sustainable, ecological society.

Placing people and the planet above profits-for-the-few demands nothing less.

Climate Crisis and the Global Green New Deal

Noam Chomsky
Robert Pollin

with C. J. Polychroniou